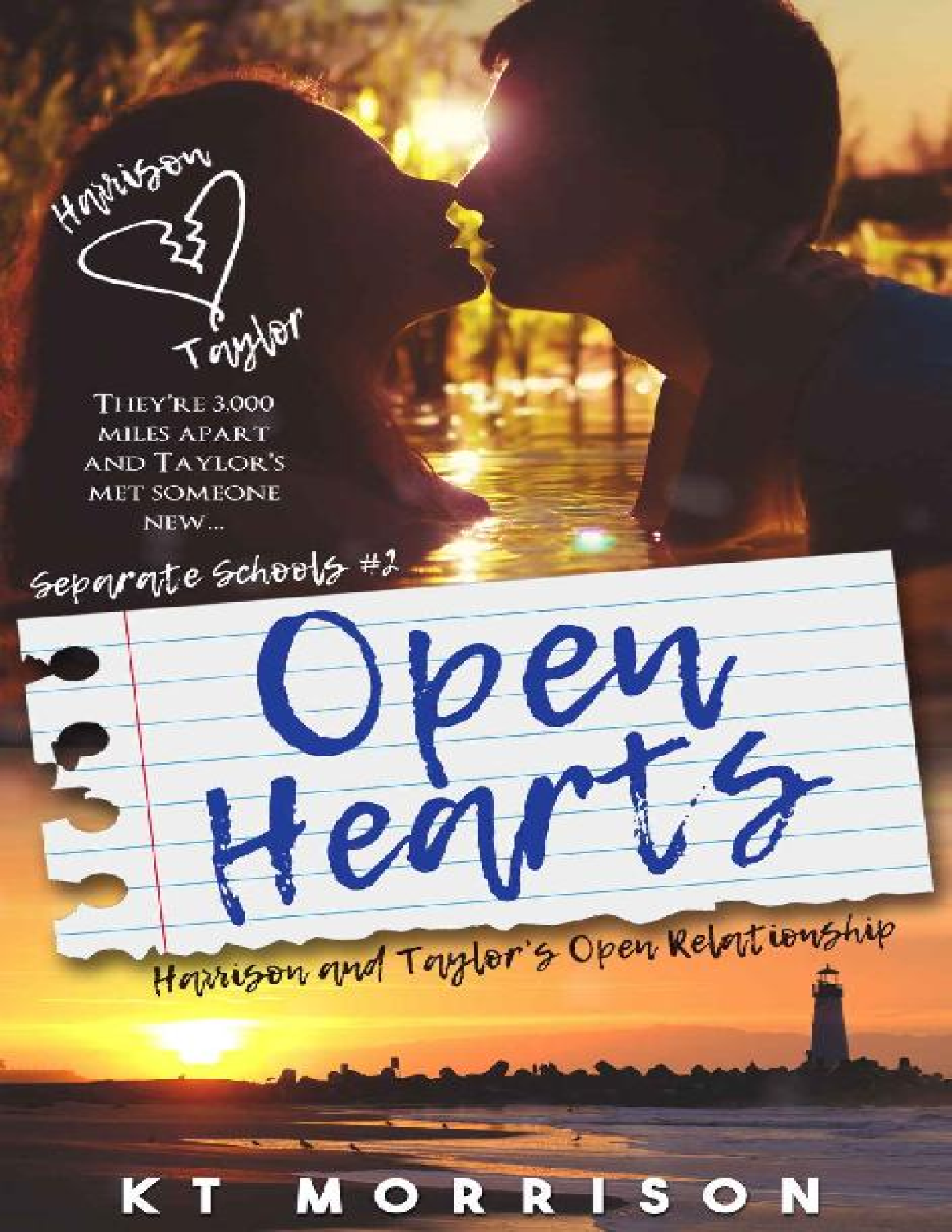


A romantic scene of a couple kissing at sunset. The woman's back is to the camera, and a handwritten note is pinned to it. The background shows a sunset over water with a lighthouse in the distance.

Harrison
Taylor

THEY'RE 3,000
MILES APART
AND TAYLOR'S
MET SOMEONE
NEW...

Separate Schools #2

Open Hearts

Harrison and Taylor's Open Relationship

KT MORRISON

OPEN HEARTS

Separate Schools #2

KT MORRISON

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

Visit My Website!

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The Taken Anthology

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All pertinent characters are over the age of eighteen.

OPEN HEARTS

A Separate Schools Novel

Separate Schools #2

41,000 words

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Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

Departure

AUGUST 27-28

Monday, August 27

Chapter One

TAYLOR

AN OBLONG of August light slanted through the bedroom window across Lana Del Rey's face. Solemn Lana, born to die and pinned above Taylor's dresser, watched over two best friends who lay together in bed.

This bedroom was her respite from the complexities of the exterior world since she was seven-years-old. Always in a flux of ever-changing renewal, it would cease to evolve beginning tomorrow. Her always-flourishing home-space would wither without her.

Various remnants described her past like archaeological proof: the interior of her walk-in closet, still in original pre-puberty pink, the rest of the room now painted the French blue of a sophisticated teen who fell in love with images of Paris in the 1950s; stickers on the wall peeled off years ago but leaving white tattered shorelines she'd never roused herself to remove; the mirror—not the pedestal one her grandfather gave her standing tall in the closet, the circular one her dad brought back from business in Mexico that hung on the wall by the door when you came in—festooned with photographs tucked in the slip between glass and bright blue Mexican tile. Those computer-printed snapshots were windows to alternate realities, and the changes she saw in the photo's subjects were confounding because sometimes it felt like all time was happening at once. Only yesterday they worried about the first day of high school. There were photos of young Taylor, Taylor and Riley, former Prom Queen Riley almost unrecognizable. KC in his uniform the first year playing at State. Boyfriend Harrison. Boyfriend Harrison when he tried to grow a mustache (God, he hated that photo, but every time he swiped it she printed a new one). Best Friend

Harrison when he was ten, giving the camera a furious but hopelessly cute smile. And lots of pictures of her and Kelsey Kay—her longtime pseudo-sister who she now lay face-to-face and knee-to-knee with overtop the duvet.

It was late afternoon, almost evening. She and Kay had packed the things she would bring to Santa Cruz: books off shelves, iPad, laptop, notebooks, clothes pulled from the closet. Three suitcases held all the things she needed. Three suitcases in a neat line at the edge of the wall where her walk-in closet met the hallway to the bedroom door. Tomorrow she would leave this place.

What a horrible mistake.

The weight of a heavy infernal blanket overwhelmed her; a woolen trap she couldn't struggle out from under. Why *had* she done this? Why was she so afraid of staying? Eight months ago, leaving Michigan seemed like the answer. The answer to what?

You know, Taylor.

She did.

Downstairs, Trish prepared dinner—Taylor's last Michigan dinner until Thanksgiving. She could smell the former favorite family special, and Trish's signature dish: Chicken Cacciatore.

"I don't want to go," she whispered to Kay.

The two of them had lay in bed now for almost half an hour. The points of their knees touched, and their feet intertwined, laying on their sides face-to-face with hands folded under cheeks and watching each other.

"This was your choice."

"I made a big mistake."

"You totally did."

"I don't think I can do it," she said, features pinching as she struggled not to cry again. Her reddened cheeks were already lined with dried tears, and her temples throbbed. An array of balled tissues dotted the pillows.

Kay said, "I'm so mad at you for this—but I *know* you can do it."

"I'm so sorry."

"I can't forgive you, Taylor, but I totally get you. I do. You're breaking my heart, but I'll always be here for you."

Kay ran hair behind Taylor's ear with black-painted fingernails, cupped her neck and stroked her cheek with a thumb.

Taylor said, "I was so strong, but now I'm not."

“You’re still strong. Whatever you need out west, you go find it. But if you don’t call me every day, I will come and get you. I’ll be at your dorm room door, and you *will* be sorry.”

She snuffled laughter now, pushed the back of her wrist into an eye socket and squeezed away tears that had been threatening. She laughed, lips and tongue thick with sadness, but so grateful to have Kay with her.

Taylor said, “What am I going to do out there without any friends?”

“You’ll find friends, Taylor.” Kay patted her cheek.

“What if I don’t want to find any friends?”

“You need friends. Promise me you’ll look. Okay? I want you to find somebody out there who’ll have your back when I don’t.”

“Why did I do this? Why did I do it, Kay?”

“Only you know. And you *know* that you know. So don’t give me any sob story right now. You know what you want and you have to go find it.”

“Without you? Without Harrison?”

“You didn’t want us, baby,” Kay said, and her confident smile faltered and she showed a look of hurt.

Taylor’s own mouth slimmed to a pursed line. She’d wanted to go away to avoid this. But going away *created* it. There was no way she could escape *herself*. No way she could escape the thoughts and fears and obligations that sunk their fingers into her every day. She couldn’t run away from them even if she went twenty-four hundred miles from home.

Now she cried again, her face twisting up, and her hand sought a dry Kleenex. She took one, brought it to her nose and blew.

“Shh, shh,” Kay soothed her, running a hand over Taylor’s collarbone and around her neck in placating sweeps, rubbing a thumb to massage her shoulder. “Don’t cry. Don’t cry. Don’t stress out.”

“I *am* stressing out. I’m *so* stressing out,” she sobbed. Her whole life was being left behind, her future reduced to three suitcases. Not even her own bedding was coming. She and Trish would stop at Target when they got off the plane in California. *Why didn’t she apply to Michigan?* “My Harrison,” she cried. “I don’t want other guys.”

Kay shushed her again, squeezing her shoulder and rocking her with one hand. “Stop, stop. You don’t have to.”

“I don’t,” she said. And she didn’t. One time with Colt was all she needed, maybe.

Kay said, “It’s there though. Whatever you want to do. Don’t feel bad.”

“How could I not feel bad?” she whispered.

Kay watched her eyes, and her mouth moved around as she struggled to put something into words. She leaned closer and kissed the point of Taylor’s chin then drew back again. She said, “Don’t stress. Fidelity is just a construct.”

Taylor smirked and blew her nose.

“It is, Taylor. Don’t let the intangible frighten you. Don’t let men put you in an invisible box.”

Taylor chuckled and blew her nose again. She murmured, “You’re so stupid,” and she rolled her head up to look at the ceiling.

Kay’s hand stroked from her shoulder to lie between her breasts. She said, “I’m not stupid. I’m serious.”

“I’m not in a man’s box.”

“Exactly. And don’t get yourself into one. Faithfulness is a male concept. If women were the dominant gender for the last few thousand years there would be no such thing as fidelity or marriage.”

Now Taylor laughed hard enough her shoulders shook, and she ran hair back from her face and tucked it underneath her head. “You’re so crazy.”

Kay laughed a little, too. She said, “No. I’m right. You have to look out for you, Taylor. Harrison is one of the good ones. He really is. Keep him. You’re not going to find another one like him. But you’ll find other good ones if you look.”

“Why do I *want* other ones?”

“You know you do. You do because you’re a woman. And you do because you should.”

“I know,” she sighed and scratched her head.

Kay said, “If men didn’t rule us we would be queens. You and I would have fiefdoms and we would pick men like ripe fruit at the market.”

Now Taylor laughed so hard she had to draw her knees up to her chest. She almost farted. Kay laughed hard as well, but Kay was serious. Kay’s laughter came from watching her laugh.

They came face-to-face again, both smiling now. Kay had the magic ability to make tears disappear. They watched each other and chewed their own cheeks. Their feet tangled and their toes gripped each other’s skin and it got them smiling wider. Kay’s hand drifted down to caress her arm then her hip. It moved up to touch Taylor just above her shorts; on the bare skin of her tummy between the pants button and her T-shirt that had ridden up.

Kay said, "You're so taut." She poked her in the middle and Taylor laughed. She put her hand down to tease the back of Kay's hand with her fingertips. Kay's index finger drew lines on Taylor's stomach, making circuits around her bellybutton.

"You're tight as a drum," Kay said.

Taylor snorted again.

Now the hand that teased Kay's wrist touched Kay on her hip and came to her friend's middle. She slipped it underneath Kay's shirt to touch her soft stomach, finding her bellybutton and slipping the tip of her finger inside. She tugged on it, like a hook in a fish's mouth.

Kay giggled. "You hardly have any bellybutton at all." Her finger stroked over the shallow of Taylor's navel, touched the knotted center.

"I'm too skinny," Taylor said.

"You're beautiful," Kelsey said.

They were silent for a long moment, watching each other's faces. The hands stopped teasing at each other's navels and just rested on the shallows of their waists. Their faces came together slowly, and Kay closed her eyes. Taylor did, too. Their lips met; soft, damp, and cool pillows that pressed each other. Kay sucked on her lips, and Taylor teased, biting gently and pulling on Kay's.

TAYLOR ASKED HER, "Do you think I'm selfish?"

"Do you think you are?"

"Harrison said I want *everything*."

"We all do. Even Harrison wants it all. He's as selfish as everyone else, but he cloaks himself in this, like, weird nobility thing he does."

"He is good," she sighed.

"He's worth teaching."

Taylor smiled and touched Kay's neck. "You're going to teach him?"

"When you get back, you won't even recognize him. I'll have him house-trained."

"No more accidents on the carpet?"

"I'll bop his nose with a rolled up newspaper."

Taylor laughed so hard she had to cover her face.

"I'll take care of him for you," Kay said.

"Do I want to know if he's seeing someone else?"

“Not at first you won’t. But eventually you will.”

“What do I do if he finds someone else? What if he leaves me?”

Kay said, “You don’t want that?”

“I know, I know,” she said. “I was ready to break up with him.”

“Not permanently. Just a break.”

“Agh, you’re right this is what I wanted...”

“You get everything you want. Being open is like a break with benefits.”

Taylor watched Kay’s face, mouth shoved to one side as she considered this. “I don’t want him to see anyone else.”

“Ew, you are selfish,” Kay loudly proclaimed.

“No, I’m not,” she laughed and swiped at Kay’s face.

Kay pushed Taylor’s hands away and taunted her. “What a selfish bitch you are, Taylor, God, you selfish, selfish bitch.” They both laughed and played at slapping each other’s face.

Taylor giggled, “Maybe I am selfish.”

“Maybe you are,” Kay sighed, and hugged her head.

“I can’t help it. It hurts my stomach—no, my *heart*—to think of him with some stupid bitch.”

“God, he’s so gullible, too. Some piece of shit who’s halfway decent looking spreads her legs for him, he’ll devote his entire life to her. She’ll dig her claws in, treat him like dirt and he’ll—”

“Don’t, Kay,” she scolded, and shoved her away.

Kay grimaced. “Sorry, Taylor.”

“You’re right,” Taylor whimpered and covered her face. The throbbing in her temples returned as she fought tears. Into her hands, she said, “Don’t let him see anybody.”

Kay’s smile thinned and her eyes clouded. She exhaled in preparation, said, “In the car yesterday, Harrison told me you had sex with Colt—why didn’t you tell me?”

A small cough of disbelief escaped her. In a cry, she lamented, “Why would he...?”

She had to turn away because the shame was overwhelming. The thing she had done with Colt was proof beyond a doubt she was the most selfish person on earth they knew. She’d convinced herself she *deserved* Colt. The audacity was astounding.

Even though she was hungry, her stomach flipped over like it wanted to dump out its contents. She sat up and lay a protective hand on her middle. Kay sat up and scooted behind her, one arm hugging around her neck.

“He couldn’t tell me *why*,” Kay whispered in her ear.

“I don’t even know why,” she moaned and held Kay’s wrist.

“It’s okay, Taylor.”

“No, it’s not.”

“Why not?”

“I shouldn’t have done it, is why.”

“It’s done now,” Kay whispered, breath tickling her ear and making her shiver.

“I thought it would be over between me and Harrison.”

“You did it before you broke up?”

Taylor sighed. “I don’t know, it was so mixed up, I...”

Her mouth clapped shut, and she stared across the room, fingers tingling with pinpricks. She slipped from Kay’s hug and stood. “Kay...”

When she turned, Kay looked guilty.

She’d been had. Harrison hadn’t told Kay a thing...

Kay’s eyes drifted down and watched her own fingers pluck at the threads in the duvet’s pattern. “Sorry,” she said.

“Harrison didn’t tell you anything.”

Kay shook her head no.

“I can’t believe you just did that to me,” she said, trace of a whine in her voice. Her hands cupped the back of her neck and she fought the urge to cry.

“I’m so sorry, pooky,” Kay said, turning her face to show Taylor an earnest and apologetic expression. “I’m mad at you for keeping it from me.”

“Can you blame me?” she said and sniffed.

“It’s not that bad.”

“KC would kill him. And what about me—what would KC think about me?”

Kay said, “Harrison lied for you?” The question came abruptly, more said to herself than to Taylor. Her head snapped to face Taylor. “Did Harrison watch?”

Oh wow, here came the tingles again, fingers *and* toes, and an unprovoked flexing of her butt and sphincter. “Watch me and Colt?” she

said with manufactured disbelief. “No.” She crossed her arms.

Kay’s head cocked, and her mouth thinned. “Did you hurt him?”

“Harrison?—Yeah. What do you think?”

“I’m sorry, please come back and sit with me.” Legs hiked apart, she patted between her knees.

That was a horrible trick to play on a friend. It could’ve been much worse. There was a burden on her, and as much as she wanted to protect herself from the chagrin and judgment of others, she’d been prepared a moment ago to bare it all, even tell Kay about her and Stevie in the boathouse and how Harrison ejaculated watching her have sex with Colt.

“Why would you treat me like that, Kay? Don’t do that to me,” she said, sitting tentatively on the bed between Kay’s ankles, arms folded.

“I do feel bad, sweetheart, I do. I didn’t think you’d fall for it.”

“I’m so stupid,” she said, closing her eyes and shaking her head. “Stupid, stupid, stupid.”

“You’re not stupid. You trust me and I’m a heartless bitch.” Kay took Taylor’s shoulders, aimed her so they faced. “I know you, Taylor. Secrets kill you. Don’t keep it inside, share it with me.”

“I’m so ashamed,” she admitted. It felt good to say it.

“Don’t be,” Kay said. “Don’t let it weigh on you. You can’t do that to yourself.”

“I know.”

“Does it feel better you told me?”

She nodded.

“Told you,” Kay said, “I know you, and I love you. Don’t make yourself hurt when you don’t have to.”

They hugged, and she squeezed Kay tight and stroked her long hair. Her friend felt so good and warm and soft under her palms. There were no more tears, just some sniffing.

She wondered if Kay was right, and the confessing of her sins to someone whose opinion she cherished absolved her in some way. They stayed in each other’s clutch for a long, quiet while, then they mutually sighed and let go. Taylor turned away and Kay scooted close to rub her back. She dug her thumbs in her collar, ran fingernails on the nape of her neck which always hardened her nipples in the weirdest way.

Kay said, “How was it with Colt?”

“Oh, ho,” she chuckled. “Huh. Yeah.”

“That good?”

“Ho, Kay...”

Kay worked the muscles of her upper back with the blunt curves of her silver rings as Taylor figured out how to put the experience into words and wondered if she even should.

Kay prompted her: “Tell me...”

“His body, Kay,” she clucked her tongue and shook her head.

“He is sexy.”

“His dick... Oh, my God, Kay, it was like... I don’t know, a beef fucking burrito.” Over her shoulder, she held her palms apart to approximate the size of Colt’s erect penis, exaggerating a little.

“Where did you guys do it?”

“My room. Kay, we did *everything*. Like, he had my feet over my head, from behind, on top, *all* over the bed... He’s so strong.”

“Was he good to you?”

“Yeah, he was. He really was. He made me...”

When she paused, Kay’s hands stilled, gripping her collar. “Made you what?...”

She whispered, “He made me come.”

Behind her, Kay gave a snuffled laugh then hugged her. “I thought you were going to say something bad.”

Taylor caressed Kay’s forearms, saying, “No, he made me... come... like, three times.”

“That’s good.”

“I know. He was *so* good in bed. And it hurt at first because he’s *way* bigger than Harrison, but he was careful.”

“Surprises abound.”

“He was fun.”

“He didn’t want to come on your face or something gross?”

“No, but... when he... when he—”

“I don’t want to know.”

It was a relief to not have to say it, and she hugged Kay’s wrists and fell back against her. No one had come in her mouth before, not even Harrison.

Kay snaked her arms around her neck and kissed her ear. Taylor said, “You didn’t want to watch me with him?”

“I had to psych myself up to watch you with Brady, and I had *months* to prepare. God, I walked in on you and Harrison and I almost had a panic

attack.”

“My tough Kelsey’s not so tough.”

“I care about you and I love you, Taylor. We’ve been friends forever. I see you like that and it...”

Kay’s eyes went pink and Taylor swore she would cry. “Hey, hey, what the heck?” She rose to comfort her, but Kay kept her hold.

“Don’t, don’t. I’m fine.” Now Kay hugged Taylor to her, pushed her face into her collar. Taylor kissed her neck.

Kay whispered in her ear, “I did get to see your little vagina in new and startling ways.”

Taylor laughed into Kay’s collar, then pushed pouted lips against her skin and snorted farts on her until Kay pushed her away.

Taylor covered her face and asked, “Did you watch *there*?”

“Did I?” Kay laughed, “You spread your legs so wide I thought Brady was going to change your diaper.”

Taylor swatted her, mouth open in horror.

“You showed me and Harrison your whole shebang, poop chute and all.”

“Hey,” she said, feeling embarrassed now.

Kay tugged her back and put an arm around her. They were close enough their noses touched. “I looked there. You’re beautiful everywhere, especially there. That’s where you’re a woman, and I swear to God, Taylor, you are perfect.”

“Okay,” she said, pouting but satisfied.

Kay said, “Did you look at mine?”

Taylor shook her head no. “But because... you know.”

“Harrison?”

She nodded.

Kay watched her eyes for a moment, then smiled.

“What?...”

Kay said, “Did you know your boyfriend has some really big balls?”

Taylor frowned and clucked her tongue. “Don’t make fun of him.”

“I’m not. Most guys brag they got big balls. Harrison actually *has* big balls.”

“I love them,” she said.

“I know you do, sweetheart. I’ll make sure no other bitch puts her fingers on them.”

A resounding five-note melody chimed through the house. The front doorbell. Kay kissed her lips once more, and they looked at each other for a few seconds. Kay drummed her fingers on Taylor's neck and said, "I think Big Balls is here."

Chapter Two

HARRISON

TAYLOR MET him at the door and they hugged in the hall. One of those hugs where you keep the person close and don't want to let them go. His hug was one-armed because under the other he held a gift basket for Taylor's mom. A nice thank-you put together by his mother because that's what you did for people like the Brooks she said. In the basket there was a bottle of wine and a selection of crackers, cheese, and charcuterie.

Kay loomed in the hall with a funny smile on her face, both hands tucked in her back pockets. When she saw them hugging, she stepped forward and took the basket from him.

Now he put both arms around Taylor. They held each other tightly in the quiet hall.

At last they separated, and while he was sad he gave her a thin smile and said nothing. He kept his hand on Taylor's waist.

"Hi, Kay," he said.

"Hey."

He said, "Smells good."

Kay said, "Yeah. I'm starving."

He said, "Trish's Chicken Cacciatore?"

Taylor said, "Uh-huh."

He nodded his chin to Kay who still held the basket between two hands. "That's for your mom. From my mom. And me."

They went into the kitchen together, walking down the hallway past the staircase and into the Brooks' big kitchen. It was brighter today than it had been yesterday and the room filled with light. Out the windows the view of

the ravine was green and hazy. Through the cathedral windows that went onto the back deck a hawk circled.

Trish darted around the kitchen in a tank top and leggings like she'd just come home from the gym. To protect her colorful gym wear she'd put on an apron that Taylor had bought her over a decade ago when she ran out of ideas close to Christmas time. A proud autumn rooster blazed the front of the frayed cotton. Trish did a double take seeing them come in, then seeing Harrison was with them, she said, "Hey, Harrison, hey buddy, good to see you."

He came between the island and the countertop and Trish met him with a wooden spoon in one hand, her other held aside because it had sauce on it. Tilting at the hips she kissed his cheeks. She smelled like perfume.

She said, "I heard you took my place at Wolf Lake."

"I did. But nowhere near as good as you."

Trish went back to stir a pot of rice. "Not what I heard," she said into the range hood. "I heard you did a great job. Lots of satisfied customers. Thanks for that."

He said, "It was nothing. Look at that tan—how *was* Myrtle Beach?"

Kay slid his gift basket onto the marble countertop of the island and climbed up onto a stool with her legs hiked wide, heels resting on the lowest rung. She said, "Yeah, how was Myrtle Beach?" Then adding slyly: "How was Mr. Sanders?"

Trish shot a look over her shoulder at Kay with a smirk. "Mr. Sanders was very nice. We had a good time."

Kay rested her chin in her palms and watched Taylor's mom work. "You guys been dating long? I didn't even know about it."

Taylor said, "Not that long."

Trish said, "Off and on. A few months now."

Taylor made a face, and Harrison thought that meant she didn't believe Trish. But what was the big deal? Who cares if she hardly knew the guy and went off to South Carolina for a weekend? People did things like that. She wasn't married anymore.

Trish changed the subject. "I can't believe my last baby is going to college."

There was a touch of sadness in her voice, and it surprised Harrison. She was rarely sentimental. It had been tough during the divorce and that was the only other time he'd seen Trish cry. He'd come over and sat with

Taylor a few times at the kitchen table, the two of them looking at each other and not saying anything while her mom cried in the family room.

Trish said, "What do I do now?"

Kay said, "Party?"

Trish laughed. "Yeah, party. That doesn't sound too bad."

As she took the chicken from the oven, putting the hot pan up on their stainless range, she said, "This is such a big house." Now she rested her hands on the counter and looked up at the fifteen-foot ceiling. "It's a big house for one person."

Harrison chilled. The idea this house would be sold was frightening. Sure it was just a big box with windows in it, but organized in neat rows within this box were countless memories. It would be terrible if he couldn't come here anymore and look around.

Taylor said, "We'll all be home for Thanksgiving."

Trish nodded, and Harrison could see her profile as she wriggled away a sad expression and forced a smile on her face. When she turned, she said, "Who's ready to eat?"

THEY ATE the Chicken Cacciatore at the kitchen table dressed with the silver dining room cutlery. Trish drank wine. A lot. She was in a good mood. Something about the meal felt final. He wondered if the others felt it as well.

This was another closing. A bookend. He'd been here for countless meals. A dozen birthdays; all of Taylor's, one of KC's, at least one of Riley's, too. A Christmas dinner; other holidays. Sometimes just an invitation because he was hanging out here after school. The home had bustled with activity back then. The Brooks kids were popular and there were always people here. They had a swimming pool. Their kids were good-looking and friendly. The house did feel strangely silent and pretty Trish looked frighteningly small and old at the head of the table.

She offered dessert and Taylor balked. Trish said, "Oh, come on, Taylor, you can eat anything. Look at that body."

Kay said, "Just eat it because you want it."

Taylor served herself a small portion and Trish said, "Get it all done when you can."

Taylor said, "Get what done?"

“When you get older, it’s too late.” Trish licked her lower lip and took a spoonful of ice cream.

Harrison did the dishes, Kay and Taylor kept him company. The two young girls sat at the island while Harrison scrubbed, and Trish offered help. He told Trish to sit down too, and she nodded, her cheeks red.

She said, “I’m going to the family room, you kids spend some time together.” She kissed the back of his neck as she passed.

It was a good point. Tomorrow they would be apart. Tomorrow he would be with Kay, but Taylor would be so far away from them.

Kay said, “You meet me tomorrow?”

He said, “I know. McMillan Hall, ten o’clock. Why don’t you just come in with me?”

She said, “I’m staying there tonight, doofus. I’m already in my dorm. Some of us don’t want to live at home.”

He said, “I don’t want to live at home.”

Kay said, “So sell your stupid car.”

“I like my car.”

Kay shrugged and waved him away like he wasn’t worth the effort and Taylor laughed.

Once the dishes were done, the three of them walked down to the basement. The Brooks’ had a sprawling finished space down there with a pool table, home gym, home theater, sauna, and a walk out to the swimming pool and a view of the ravine beyond.

Kay stood at the side of the pool table and bounced the eight ball in rolling vectors from bumper to bumper, catching it then launching again.

It would’ve been nice to have some time naked and alone, but that was going to be impossible with Trish in the house, anyway. And he only had fifteen more minutes. It wasn’t like they could sneak off and climb into bed together, and he could kiss her and make love to her before she went away.

Kay had been in the car yesterday and suspected what they’d done, so he felt okay saying to Taylor: “It’s a good thing you came and saw me in that gas station in Whittemore.”

Kay laughed.

Taylor said, “It always seems like you have more time.”

“Ain’t that the truth,” Kay said catching the rolling ball again.

Harrison said, “I have to go. My mom’s expecting me. I got a million things to do.”

Taylor said, "I know."

Kay said, "Oh shit. I'm the third wheel—look at me." She sunk the eight ball in the corner pocket, rings clicking off its hard surface. "My bad, guys. Harrison... H-Boy... McMillan Hall, tomorrow. Ten A.M."

"See you tomorrow," he said.

Kay gave a curt nod and a sly, slanted smile. "I'll be upstairs," she said, and trotted up where she would probably go and sit with Trish in the family room and get all the gossip on Mr. Sanders.

Taylor said, "Let's go outside."

OUT THE FRENCH doors and across the deck, they walked around the pool where a Kreepy-Krawler wandered the concrete bottom, keeping it spotless. At the far end of the deck there was a pathway that led down a wooded slope to the ravine. They stopped at the gate; he opened it and let Taylor go through, and they walked down to the rocky edge of the thin waterway running behind her house. Up the slope on the opposite bank was Kay's subdivision. The ravine had narrowed to a trickle, but its meager water babbled down a two-foot high rocky waterfall. They stood together side-by-side and watched it for a moment.

Taylor said, "Harrison. I'm sorry."

An instantaneous dread seized him. Was this the breakup? Was this where she said she'd come to her senses. *We just can't be open, Harrison. What are we thinking?*

When he looked at her she said, "Sorry for what I did."

"What did you do?"

She rolled her eyes and her face look instantly childish. She said, "Colt." Her voice was quiet but heavy with dread.

He shrugged. What she'd done was horrible, but it was meant to be. He said, "Thank you."

"That's it?"

He said, "I don't know what to say."

"I can't believe you don't hate me," she said.

"I don't."

"What I said in the bathroom in Whittemore?... I mean it."

"What did you say?"

“That I’ll tell you everything. I can’t believe we’re going to do this, but I really do want to.”

“I do, too,” he said. His hand brushed around at her side until he felt her thigh, her fingers found his, and they held hands. The water babbled and gurgled and they watched it. This was a secret space. When they were little, it was hard to believe it existed. It seemed so far away from their suburb. The space had felt huge and enormous, the woods like they were enchanted, but now they were nineteen and heading off to university and engaging in a very adult relationship the woods felt tiny and sparse. They’d come out here during parties and kissed. There was a rock just behind them where you could sit by the waterfall and in the springtime when it was thick with runoff the water rushed. He fingered Taylor sitting on that rock for the first time, and she’d put her hand inside his pants.

He said, “I wish this wasn’t goodbye. I feel like we just don’t have enough time.”

“Me too. I wish I had a few more days.”

“Trish is taking you to the airport?”

“Yeah. Bright and early. Oh, my God,” she added.

“What?”

“My dad’s coming.”

“Oh, yeah?” he said brightly. “That’s cool.”

She said, “I haven’t seen him in so long.”

“Say hi to him for me.”

“I will,” she said.

They were silent for a while, but he knew Taylor had more to say and was working it over how she’d say it. She faced him, but looked away. She said, “You know I’m going away for school.”

“This is news to me,” he said.

She squished his hand and laughed. “I mean, I’m going *for* school, I’m not going out there to meet guys. Kay said you were worried I want to fall in love. I’m not going out there to fall in love. I’m going there to go to school. I’m going out there to get an education. I’m not looking for sex.”

“You’re right.”

“Did you think that?”

“It’s hard not to.”

She said, “I get it. I’m not going out there looking for anybody. I’m going there for one thing.”

“Surfing,” he said.

She laughed so hard she yanked her hand away, covered her face to laugh into her hands. When her hands came away, he saw she had tears in her eyes. But still she smiled.

“Yes,” she said. “I’m going there for surfing.”

He said, “I want you to have everything you want, Taylor.”

“Thank you,” she said with an emotionally constricted voice.

He said, “I mean it. I’ve been thinking about it and I want it for you. But don’t shut me out.”

“I won’t.”

“No, I’m serious. Tell me everything.”

“I said I would.”

“Good. Talk to me every day. I know you maybe wanted to get away from me...”

“It’s not that.”

“I get it. I’m demanding, but I don’t want to be. I won’t say a thing. Just call me and confess things to me.”

“Confess?”

“Or you don’t have to say a thing you don’t want, I just want to hear your voice.” Now he was getting choked up.

“Okay,” she squeaked again and when he put his arms out to hold her she fell against him. She buried her face in his collar with her hands tucked up to her chin.

He said, “Just do it so I won’t hurt. Even if you just leave me a voice message. Just tell me how your day was. It was good or if it was bad. And if you want something from me, let me know and I’ll do it right away.”

“You’re so good to me.”

“I could be better,” he said, and he rubbed her back. Over her shoulder he checked his watch. *Fucking shit*. He was already in trouble. “Hey,” he said now putting a knuckle under her chin to lift her face. “Kiss me.”

They kissed softly and sweetly for a minute, the whole while his heart pounding for Taylor, his mind screaming at him to get home because his mother was going to kill him. “I should go,” he whispered.

They strolled together back up to the house from the ravine, went around the side gate and out to the driveway. She said, “I’m going to miss the Soob.”

“She’ll miss you, too. Maybe I’ll pick you up from the airport in November.”

“You better,” she said.

“I guess this is it,” he said as they came to stop at his driver side door.

She said, “Even if we don’t talk every day, you can leave me a message. I want to know how your day is.”

“Only if you want.”

“I do. You’re my best friend.”

“You’re *my* best friend,” he said.

“*And* you’re my boyfriend,” she said as a clear reminder in case he thought he might’ve been shifted to the friend zone. “You’re my boyfriend and I love you,” she said as her lips came closer to his. They kissed one more time and his lips were already sore from the ravine.

He said, “Call me tomorrow. Let me know you got in okay and that you’re happy.”

She nodded, her normally pretty mouth twisted in a down-turned bow like a single drawn line. She couldn’t speak or she would cry.

“That’s it,” he said, “be tough.”

And giving *her* words of strength made him feel it, too. He kissed her forehead now, and she stroked his neck, and when they parted, the absence of her hands felt cold and he hunched up his shoulders as he dropped into the Soob and started it up.

She stood on her driveway, hugging herself, looking like a little girl with her hunched posture and dipping knees; and this might be the last time he would see her as a girl—they were all moving on, moving to adulthood. Taylor would go away tomorrow and leave their world, leave their suburb fantasy land, stretch out of her childhood and become a woman. The way she stood was childlike, standing in her driveway where they’d hung out as kids, ran down to get a popsicle from the ice cream man when they’d heard him coming while swimming in her pool; one time she’d fallen and skinned a knee badly showing Harrison a trick on a skateboard she had no right to be on, and she’d laughed that day instead of cried, hugged her knee as the brightest blood he’d ever seen seeped between her fingers... This was the spot he’d introduced her to his new car he’d purchased from his mom, and Taylor had christened it The Soob.

He gave her a nod, a firm eye contact brimming with shoddily manufactured strength, and she smiled weakly. He eased his car forward,

waved and drove away, his heart crushed in his chest. He continued on around the crescent of the Brooks' grand driveway, turned right and didn't look back.

Tuesday, August 28

Chapter Three

HARRISON

HARRISON BACKED the Soob into a spot in the short-term parking lot out front of MBS airport and locked it.

In the concourse, walking alongside the American Airlines counter, a hand grabbed his neck from behind and squeezed.

“Heya, buddy,” a familiar voice said. The hand was large and strong and Harrison knew it was Taylor’s father before he even turned.

Mr. Brooks had to be almost fifty now. The same face, those same happy features, but it was like the rest of him was unrecognizable now. His thinning hair was gone. And in an effort to alleviate his baldness he’d run with it. His head was shaved, but he showed silvery speckles above his ears. Mr. Brooks had been an athlete at one time if you looked at the pictures on the walls at Taylor’s house when they were kids and before Trish took some of them down. But Harrison had never known him that way. To him he was the quintessential dad. Like a TV dad. He liked barbecue, he watched a lot of sports, he loved his kids (loved his football son, loved and fretted about his daughters), and he loved his wife. Apparently not enough. He’d been hefty, and now he was even heftier. He had to be almost two hundred and fifty pounds, and his shirt was tucked in, making a belly that slumped over his belt.

“Holy shit—I mean, sorry, I mean, wow, Mr. Brooks. I haven’t seen you in so long.” Harrison clutched a paper bag to his chest and he kept it there as he went in for a hug with the big guy. Mr. Brooks gave him a good squeeze, thumped him on the back hard.

“Mike, Harrison.”

“What?”

“Mike. You can call me Mike now. I hear you’re off to MSU.”

“I am.”

“Let me look at you,” he said, and held Harrison back at arms length with two hands on his shoulders. His face made elastic movements as he surmised his daughter’s longtime friend and boyfriend. “Look at you. Look at you, kid. Man. I’m sorry, man. You’re really growing up.” He patted Harrison’s shoulders and let him go. He put his hands in his pockets now and looked at the floor, saying, “Where does the time go?”

Harrison said, “Tell me about it,” and opened his stance to head down the hall, Mike joining him, the two of them walking between bustling airport patrons rolling wheeled luggage. “Can you believe she’s going to California?”

“No, I can’t,” Mr. Brooks said, “she didn’t even tell me.”

Harrison could commiserate but he kept his mouth shut. She didn’t tell him, either. Instead, he said, “She plays her cards close to her chest,” then felt funny for some reason mentioning Taylor’s chest to her father even though it was innocent. He’d always been wary of Mr. Brooks because the guy loved Taylor so much.

“You got that right. She certainly does.”

They were silent as they navigated the foot traffic. His phone buzzed in his pocket and he withdrew it, feeling the dread already. Three texts he’d missed. On purpose.

KK: I’m at McMillan

KK: I’ve been here for a while

KK: You know what I mean?

He was texting her sorry but before he finished typing, she’d already pinged him, seeing his profile coming online.

KK: You’re at the airport aren’t you?

Mr. Brooks was one half stride behind, watching over his shoulder. Harrison smiled at him, showed him the phone and said, "Kelsey Kay."
Mike said, "Kelsey? Tell her I said hi."

Harrison: Mr. Brooks says Hi

KK: Are you at the airport?

Harrison: Maybe

Mr. Brooks said, "What's she doing now? She's going to state, right? I know she's not going to California..."
"Yeah, she's going to state."

KK: I'm so fucking mad right now

Harrison: I'm sorry

KK: Lose my number

Harrison: I said I'm sorry

KK: Who is this? I said lose my number. I'll get a new best friend at orientation

Harrison: I'm really sorry I know I shouldn't be here

KK: Sorry can't talk, made new friends, roster's full, they'll pair you up with whoever's left now. Good luck in all your future endeavors

Harrison said to Mr. Brooks, "I'm supposed to meet Kay for orientation right now. She's really mad at me. But she says Hi."
Mr. Brooks chuckled and winced, said, "Nice knowing you."

Harrison texted Kay.

Harrison: Please meet me tonight

KK: Where?

Harrison: The KFC on the east side. Around 7

KK: Maybe. Bring me a gift

Harrison: There's no gift shop here

KK: You're going to have to figure something out. Say hi to Mike for me

Harrison: I really am sorry

KK: whatever. Give Tay Tay a big kiss for me you loser

THEY FOUND Trish and Taylor standing together amidst a big group of California-bound travelers. They stood by a long glass wall near a maze of people lined in roped-off alleys. Trish wore a black tank top and a light cotton army green skirt and tan strapping sandals with heels. She eyed Mike over Harrison's shoulder but gave no smile.

Taylor was watching her mother, and now she followed Trish's gaze to see where she looked. Taylor wore a T-shirt and jeans, tight ones that bunched at her slender ankles over her Adidas. Her hair was pulled back from her pretty face, and she wore gold earrings. Her head oscillated to the right in a steady line and he couldn't help smiling in anticipation of her seeing him. He was not supposed to be here. She was not expecting him. But it was her father she reacted to.

Taylor's mouth dropped, and she instantly cried. And then she was twelve years old again, running into her father's arms. She cried *Daddy!*

and jumped into his bearhug. Mike took his daughter and wound her around in circles with her feet off the floor. He growled and groaned to fight back his own tears. Harrison took them up for him instead and had to brush wet away from his eyes. Father and daughter, an amazing bond between her and Mr. Brooks. Somehow they'd grown distant and Taylor hardly mentioned him these days. Sometimes he thought of the phrase: out of sight, out of mind.

"Oh, Taylor, oh, God, my baby's going to California," he growled. Taylor kicked her feet, and Harrison noted the bright white and clean soles of her brand-new-for-school shoes. Taylor would have stressed over what the kids were wearing in California these days and he was sure this look she sported was cultivated from Instagram.

Mike set her feet down, but they didn't let each other go. "Oh, Daddy," Taylor cried, and buried her face into his shirt. When they did finally part, Harrison saw that Mike had shed tears as well and his face had gone red. His shirt showed dark where his daughter had cried.

Mr. Brooks grabbed at his belt, pulled up his pants, swiped a hand to tuck his shirt that had come undone when he hoisted his daughter off her feet. He said, "God, Taylor, I feel like I haven't seen you in a year."

"I'm sorry," she said.

"It's okay," he said, "I love you so much." He cupped her cheek, and she held his wrist. "God, you're my baby, baby girl."

Now it was Trish's turn, stepping in to extinguish this tender moment. "Hi, Mike," she said with a chill but kissed his cheek.

"Hey, Trishy," he said and patted her waist. They stepped back without looking at each other, but Mike said, "You believe this, Trish? You believe this?" He eyed their daughter. Taylor smiled.

Trish crossed her arms and smirked. She said, "I can't stand it."

Mike said, "I can't stand it, either. I was just saying to this guy"—he thumbed to Harrison—"where does the time go?"

"It's gone," Trish said.

"Stop," Taylor said and wiped at her cheeks again. She faced her parents still and hadn't acknowledged him yet. He felt a sudden pang like this had been a mistake to come today. They'd said goodbye yesterday. It was perfect yesterday. *Leave her alone.* Kay was right.

But then she turned and threw her arms around his neck and kissed his lips. The paper bag rustled between them and he hooped an arm around her

waist and kissed her in return.

Taylor said, "What are *you* doing here?"

"I'm sorry. I couldn't... If you're still in Michigan I want to see you."

"We said goodbye yesterday."

"I brought you something. I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry," she said, softening and smiling.

"I am. I shouldn't have come."

"No, Harrison, don't do that. Don't..." She held his wrist with two hands as if afraid he might leave.

He said, "I'm sorry. I'll let you say goodbye to your dad. I just wanted to see you one more time."

"You're so sweet," she said.

"Kay's going to kill me," he said and rubbed his head.

"She's totally going to kill you. You didn't tell her you were coming?"

"She would've stopped me."

"Oh, shoot. She's at McMillan waiting for you?"

He nodded.

Taylor said, "Looks like I *will* need a new boyfriend."

Harrison grimaced and bit his lower lip.

Taylor realized what she said and her brow lowered. "Sorry."

"I really should go," he said.

"What did you have to bring me?"

He looked over her shoulder to see Mike and Trish watching and now he was way too embarrassed. He said, "It's nothing."

She said, "What is it?"

He got close to her so they wouldn't see what he'd brought. He opened the bag, slipped out its lone stuffed content. A teddy bear. He showed it to her and said, "I don't want you to sleep alone."

She aww-ed him and touched the bear's button nose. He slipped it back in the bag before anyone else would see. He said, "He doesn't have anything on."

"Ooh-la-la," Taylor said.

He said, "No, I mean he *needs* something..." He looked in Taylor's eyes and she returned his gaze not knowing what he meant. "He needs pajamas," Harrison said quietly. "Needs something to wear. Maybe like... A baby onesie or something."

Taylor's lips were parted as she listened, and when he said that, her mouth closed with a quiet pop. Her eyes darted over his. He said, "You know... To sleep in."

She continued to stare in his eyes and he looked away.

Trish and Mike still watched.

He said, "Shit. I shouldn't have come." He stepped back from Taylor but she grabbed his shirtsleeves and pulled him back. She took the paper bag from him without saying anything and tucked it under her arm. She got close, and he put his arms around her and rubbed her back. Then he kissed her forehead, and she turned her chin up so he kissed her lips one more time. He said, "Say bye to your family. Call me when you get there and let me know you're okay. But I'm going now." His voice broke on the last word and he knew he couldn't say anymore. He kissed her one more time and she let him linger.

She whispered, "I love you."

"I love you, too," he said with remaining strength. He cleared his throat, nodded to her and kissed her on the forehead one more time, turned and left. He managed one croaky *Bye, Mike, bye, Trish* and waved at them quickly.

"Bye, Harrison," they both said, smiling with sad eyes knowing this poor young boy was having his heart broken.

Chapter Four

TAYLOR

THE ROOM where she would live from now to next May was on the fourth floor of the Fleming building on the south side of the campus. With palm trees astride the modern glass and steel foyer it gave the impression of a mid-level tropical hotel. When she was eight, Mom, Dad, and all the kids drove to Disney World. A singularly fond family memory that set the standard. Relationships later soured; teenage years wrought havoc on the Brooks, and the kids are only three years apart. The best memories had been the earliest ones and eventually every event became an attempt to re-create them. That summer they visited Disney World, they stayed in an Econo Lodge outside Orlando. Its modest hallways and rooms were nearly identical to the Fleming; glossy paint on concrete block walls, steel doors set in steel frames, thin navy carpet marked with geometric patterns that muffled at least some of the din. It was moving day, and the hallway bustled. Countless voices rolled in an undulating murmur; doors banged, stereos blared, objects dropped onto the floor. Taylor's heart raced.

Trish walked a pace behind her through the throng, and anytime Taylor glanced over her shoulder she found her mother smiling and taking it all in. Of the two Brooks women here today in Santa Cruz, Trish was the most eager.

A boy leaned in a doorway wearing only a towel. He was thin, but he had visible stomach muscles. With a backwards baseball hat he ogled all the passing girls from behind orange Oakley sunglasses. Trish caught his eye and his head swiveled to follow her, the kid smiling around a toothbrush plugged in his cheek. Taylor's mother was never afraid of men—even

bolder in these later *single* years—and she met the boy’s gaze with a confident eye and a smirk, walking past and letting her own head swivel. The boy didn’t wither. Trish chuckled and grinned at Taylor.

The fact that Taylor would be on a coed dorm floor had intrigued and worried her mother. *Coed dorm? That doesn’t mean what I think it means, does it?* But seeing her mother’s confidence as she strutted the dorm hall made her envious. Trish attracted attention, but it was something Taylor had come to terms with after the divorce. At forty-eight, here Trish was turning heads in a dorm room full of freshmen. Five-nine with glossy chestnut hair pulled back in a youthful ponytail, Trish smiled with all-natural bright white charm at these young and assuredly horny guys, fostering all sorts of MILF fantasies for them over the next few nights.

Maybe not fantasies.

First year is a fuckfest.

Hadn’t Care Bear alluded to the bacchanalian festival he believed it to be? And what would it be like for Harrison? Would dear sweet Harrison end up in the hungry clutch of some freshman skank who would suck him dry of his loving nutrients like some sort of spider queen?

It was a horrible thought; one she was quick to dismiss.

They rode a crowded elevator together to the fourth floor with a bunch of snickering kids and a mother and father and their quiet son. The parents gave and received sympathetic nods to and from Trish. The small space stank of coconut tanning oil and bubblegum. On the fourth floor, they emerged in a phalanx of students, Trish getting ahead of her, eyes turned up to decipher the signage that would direct them to her daughter’s dorm room, getting Taylor’s eye and pointing to the right. Part way down the hall she caught up with her mother, and together they weaved their way to 420.

Yup, 420, the number of the room where she would be residing. And just in case no one got it, she discovered that someone had drawn a crude-looking marijuana leaf in ball point right under her room number placard. Trish for sure saw it and Taylor didn’t want to know whether or not Trish got the 420 reference.

“Aw, sweetie, this is your room,” Trish said, opening the door with one hand but hanging back so Taylor could go ahead.

It was thankfully empty, though her roommate had already checked in. The left half of the room had a bedspread on the bed, a table lamp on its cheap chipboard night table, and clothes hung in the tall doorless closet

space. Above the bed was a poster of a black guy, maybe a singer, good-looking, tattooed, his suit jacket open and not wearing a shirt, showing off his shiny stomach muscles.

The right side was a blank space; her space. And nothing at all like the wonderful room she'd grown up in in Saginaw, that Taylor-space where she was queen, in a neighborhood where she was cherished.

She stepped in and tossed her bag on the bare bed. A window divided two halves of the room; right square between two beds, sunny California beyond. The walls were painted a glossy dove gray that was probably easy to wash; bare unmade single bed set in a wood-printed-veneer plywood frame. A night table with her own lamp. She hadn't thought to bring posters, hadn't brought any decoration at all. While Trish stood in the doorway still, watching her surely, she stood in the center of the room and looked around, shuffling her feet and transcribing a full circle.

"What do you think?" Trish asked.

"It'll do," she said, smirking because she thought a funny answer was in order though she didn't feel funny. Her stomach felt squeezed like there was a sickly hand, a leprous hand, inside her curling its diseased fingers through her organs to surround her guts.

Trish watched her, eyes going up and down her daughter, and Taylor wondered how much she gave away. How much of the sandstorm inside her was visible to the outside? She was *of* her mother, was her mother the same? Did Trish ever feel pushed under the thumbprint of something huge and uncaring? Did she ever feel like the external pressures were too much? Did the act of breathing sometimes—for Trish or maybe even her father—ever seem a labor?

Trish cleared her throat and said, "You put that credit card somewhere safe, Taylor."

She nodded. "I have it in my pocketbook," she said, chinning at her bag on the bed. Her father had gifted her a brand-new phone and a credit card he told her he would keep topped up. Reminded her though to keep it sensible. She said, "And I have to transfer all my stuff to my new phone."

"Do it before school starts," Trish said, "you don't want to have to be thinking about things like that once classes have started."

Taylor told her she knew, then folded her arms—more so she could hug herself, stroke the backs of her upper arms with her fingers. The two of them stared at each other, and while she wanted to be alone, came all this

way to be alone, the idea of Trish leaving right now scared her to death. She licked her upper lip to say something, feeling that overwhelming bewilderment coming over her again. *All those people in the hall behind her mother; why can't she just close the door...*

As if reading her mind, Trish put her hand on the doorknob and moved to close it.

There was a voice outside in the hall that separated itself from the cacophonous din. A male mid-sentence, talking to someone else very close, and she could see now a tall kid just outside her door; blonde-haired guy in a college sweatshirt, talking to someone at his side who was passing by. They laughed, and Trish paused a moment giving the young man a chance to poke his head inside. With a big smile, he said, "Hey, what's up, New-Arrival...?"

Trish and him were almost face-to-face; Taylor watched this guy register how pretty her mom was. Could see his smile slide into slyness and his eyes narrow. Trish and him were close, eyes going over each other, and this guy pushed himself inside a little further and leaned on the jamb. He said, "Looks like Michigan's finally here."

Trish asked: "How'd you know we're from Michigan?"

"Oh, yeah? You're *both* from Michigan? What are the chances, two roommates from the same place."

"Very funny. You know I'm her mother."

"Wasn't sure," he said in a tune, and smirked.

Trish folded her arms and leaned on the open dorm room door. "Little boys these days act awful grown up."

"Oh, wow, you two are trouble," the kid said and offered his hand. "I'm Tripp."

Now it was Trish's turn to smirk and she let the young guy shake her hand. "That's my daughter, Taylor."

Tripp let Trish go and put his hands in the pouch on the front of his Santa Cruz sweatshirt. "Pleased to meet you, Taylor," he said now, smirking again and bouncing on his toes.

"Hi, Tripp, bye, Tripp," she said, and had wanted to say something like that to someone for a long time. Tripp looked like he could take it and her shields were up, anyway.

Tripp *could* take it. He laughed, said, "Ho, man, Michigan girls are *cold*," and took a step back.

Trish walked the door closed and said, "It's the long winters, we'll see you around, Tripp."

Big smile, Tripp leaned in past Trish and said, "See you around, Taylor."

She couldn't help smiling at the guy, and he caught her.

Before Trish closed the door, Tripp headed down the hall. Trish stepped out to watch him go.

"Oh, my God, Taylor," she said, "look at that kid's ass."

"Gross, Mom, don't. He's like nineteen years old."

"Easy, Taylor," Trish said. "I didn't pinch it or anything, I just have eyes in my head." She closed the door now and leaned her back on it. "You okay?"

"I'm fine," she said, opening a suitcase to keep her hands busy.

"You know who Eddie Haskell is?"

"No."

Trish shrugged, disappointed. "That kid is an Eddie Haskell. A *hot* Eddie Haskell."

"Whatever," she said and put a stack of shorts into a dresser drawer.

"You going to hang out with him?"

"Tripp? I have a boyfriend, Mom. Harrison? Remember him?"

"Easy, Taylor, please." Trish came to stand behind her. "I said hang out with him. That's all."

"I don't know, Mom. I just got here. I'm trying to unpack."

"Let me make your bed for you."

She grunted before saying, "Okay. Fine."

Trish took the bedding out of the plastic Target bags and unzipped the packaging. "We should take them to the laundry first," she said.

"Please, can we just... they're *fine*."

Trish made up the bed while Taylor unpacked her clothing. Outside the dorm room door people yelled and laughed and banged the walls and played loud music. Taylor hung up her clothes in silence, then got out her iPad and laptop.

When the bed was made, she stood at the dresser and her mother came from behind and put arms around her. She let herself be hugged, and Trish rocked her.

"I don't want to be here, Mom. Why did I come here?"

"You're going to be okay, Taylor. I'm so proud of you."

"Proud of me why?"

“You’re so brave. So smart.”

“I’m so stupid.”

“Stop, Taylor. I know you’re scared. I know you’re alone. That’s why I’m so proud of you. You’re here anyway. You made it.”

A plain, sun-washed grass field spread out front of the dorm building and her window looked over it. Beyond the blades of the palm tree she saw carefree people her own age with easy smiles and shouted banter tossing a frisbee. Others walked in groups; two guys trundled a library cart down the concrete path and a third hung off it, along for the ride; an Asian girl ran behind two boys and when one turned she offered him a can of Coke. They hugged. Did everyone else know each other? There were no familiar faces to be seen. But as frightening as it might seem, that was why she was here. It would be easier to get lost.

Her breath came in quiet chugs, and she held back sobs from her voice as she said, “Take me... to... dinner...?”

“Sure thing, baby,” her mom whispered.

The door opened behind them and the room filled with the voices and bravado from the hall. She wiped her cheeks and eyes before turning around, slipping out of her mother’s hug.

Coming in the room now was a girl around her same age she figured had to be her roommate—a black girl (though she knew any color girl could have a black R&B singer on their wall). The girl came in and saw the two new arrivals—her roommate and roommate’s mother—and her mouth tightened. She slipped both hands into her front pockets and looked at them without saying anything.

Trish said, “Is this your room, too?”

The girl nodded, said, “Hey,” then passed them and sat heavily on the dorm room bed opposite hers. She had a pretty face, and *really* pretty hair pulled back at the sides and held in clips. There were two separate almost-pigtails or ponytails that weren’t quite dreadlocks but still held together in individual tendrils. They had been dyed sort of an amber color, or maybe bleached. The girl was looking at Taylor’s sneakers and she realized they both had the same shoes.

“Hey,” she said brightly, and wagged one foot.

The girl nodded, said, “Cool.”

Trish said, “This is Taylor, I guess she’s your roommate.”

“Hey, what’s up, Taylor,” the girl said.

“Nice to meet you,” she said.

The girl looked around a bit, then said, “I’m Makayla.”

Trish said, “Makayla is a pretty name.”

Taylor shot her a look—an *I don’t need your help* look. Trish might make things worse.

Her mom said, “All right, I’m going to be outside... if you want to go out with me, be down by fifteen, we’ll head into the city or something. Sound all right?”

“Yeah, that’s good,” she said without looking at her mother. Trish slipped out into the hallway traffic and was gone.

Taylor sat down on her bed opposite, their knees pointing at each other. Makayla had her hands clasped, and the R&B singer was above her like an exclamation mark.

Taylor said, “That was my mom.”

“I figured,” she said.

“I just moved in.”

Makayla said, “Yeah, I know. I’ve been here a couple days.”

They both nodded slowly and Makayla studied her, eyes moving from point-to-point and taking her in, her clothes, her figure, her hair, her face...

Taylor said, “I’m from Michigan. How about you?”

The girl said she was from Georgia and Taylor said she’d never been there before except for driving through.

Makayla said, “You got a boyfriend?”

She slumped, turned her eyes up to the ceiling. She said, “Yeah. Super complicated. He’s still in Michigan, we’re doing a long distance thing, and I hate that he’s at home and I’m here. You know? Like, I’ve been seeing him for so long and now it’s like a ninety-degree turn and he’s not in the car with me anymore...” Her voice trailed off, and Makayla stared. She looked to the closed door room door.

When she looked back, Makayla was still watching her with uninterested eyes. Brows up, lids down drowsily, she said, “At school. I meant here. Like, you think you gonna try have a guy in this room all the time...”

Absence

SEPTEMBER 11-13

Tuesday, September 11

Chapter One

HARRISON

TUESDAYS WERE his longest days of classes and he was on campus from ten in the morning until five o'clock. Kelsey convinced him to eat dinner with her on Tuesdays but he had to buy. They were in the Soob, waiting in line at the Wendy's Drive-thru.

Kay wore her sunglasses in the car, pulled down to the tip of her nose so she could see over the top of them. She was peering back, looking behind the cedar hedge that separated the restaurant from the adjacent plaza.

"I think there's an Indian restaurant back there."

"We're already in line," he said, "I'm blocked in."

"Not now. I mean next week," she said, turning to sit forward again and straightening her leather jacket.

"We can try it. What do you want to order?"

She counted off her items by bending back her ringed fingers with the pointed index of her other hand. "Spicy chicken wrap, bacon cheese potato, Sprite. Large."

ACROSS from the campus there was a slim green space next to the Greyhound station where they parked. Wendy's bags in hand they crossed the mowed patch, into the trees, found three picnic benches in the shade. There was no one else around, but they could still hear the heavy traffic on South Harrison.

While he ate his Single, she picked through her potato. They shot the shit, talked about school. The only classes they shared were Logic 1200 and

Communication 1380. She talked about her roommates. She had three and said she was over it already, said she should have bought a Soob. Then said she should get her own apartment. If she wanted, she would. Big Jim Miller gave his daughter whatever she wanted, but she rarely asked for a thing.

First time he visited her at the dorm she introduced him to her roommates as her boyfriend, saying he doesn't look like much but this guy *fucks*. In front of them she asked him if he thought the top bunk she slept in was sturdy enough to support their lovemaking. All the girls watched with open eyes and closed mouths, already afraid of her. Typical Kelsey, quick to establish dominance, even if it was done through simple wild pronouncements. She had let them all off the hook eventually, saying she was kidding, elbowing Harrison and saying he was her best friend's boyfriend.

While he spooned his Frosty, she held her chicken wrap in two hands, watching it with a cheerless frown.

"What's wrong?"

"It's like a beef burrito," she said, eyeing the wrap.

"It's... *chicken*..." he offered, having no idea what she meant.

She set it down on the open paper, shivered and looked up to the sky. When she looked back to him, she plucked her sunglasses off, folded them and put them in an inside pocket.

Now she squinted at him, mouth quirked aside, face scrunched.

"What's going on?" He laughed and pushed his spoon down into the Frosty.

She inhaled, paused. "She told me."

"Told you what?"

"For real. I mean it, Harrison. Taylor told me about Colt."

His hands wriggled, and he rubbed the pads of his cold fingers on the inside of his palm. "What *about* Colt?"

"She told me what happened. She told me she slept with him."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"You're a good boyfriend, Harrison. You don't have to cover for her, she told me. Didn't she tell you she told me?"

"No." The truth was Taylor had texted him every day for the first four days. But then she stopped. He called and left a message. She called a day later, and it was her turn to leave him a message. The last thing he wanted to talk about was Colt or Kelsey when he finally spoke to her.

Kelsey said, “We talked about it. She told me she was with him in her bedroom.” She raised her eyes to meet his. “She told me you watched.”

His reaction was instant. He made a quiet hissing sound and his thighs tightened. He flexed his arms and eased himself back on the picnic bench, grimacing. “She told you that?”

“It’s okay. Don’t worry...”

“Don’t worry? She told you I watched her? What did she say?”

“It doesn’t matter, Harrison. It doesn’t. I care about you... Why wouldn’t you share this with me? I’m part of the team. Why would you guys shut me out?”

“Oh, I don’t know. How about the shame?” Now he leaned forward and put his elbows on the table, hung his head and raked his fingers through his hair.

“Don’t be ashamed,” she said, and her hand rested on his shoulder. “Don’t be.”

“Don’t be ashamed? I watched her, and I didn’t do anything.”

“What would you do?”

“I don’t know. Shouldn’t I have done something? Shouldn’t I have stopped it?”

“You couldn’t stop him.”

“Not him. Couldn’t I have stopped Taylor?”

“Why? Why stop her? She wants to do it...”

“Fuck sake. I’m so weak,” he said to the clouds.

“You’re not.”

“You don’t think so? You don’t think it makes me look weak?”

“Not at all. I don’t think it makes you look weak.”

“Doesn’t a woman want a man who wants to own her? Wants to *possess* her... Wouldn’t she want me to kick the door down and grab that guy off her?”

“Who are you, Robert Mitchum?”

“Who’s that?”

“I don’t know—some old-time actor, like from the fifties. You want to be like that? You think girls like that? It’s not 1950 anymore, Harrison. It’s 2018. Life is not black-and-white like those old movies. This is a new world, trust me. Maybe that used to make sense, but our lives are streaming online in high definition, we’re all thirty-second YouTube clips. You’re not

some tough guy who doesn't share emotions and slaps a woman to keep her in her place."

"That's not what I'm saying at all."

"You think it makes you look weak? *You* make you look weak."

"What the hell does that mean?"

She opened her wrap, spreading it like she was gutting a fish, plucked the fried chicken bits and popped a portion in her mouth. Food tucked into one cheek, she said, "The weakness is *in* you. Not what you do."

"That doesn't make any sense, Kay."

She inhaled, wiped her hands, tried a new angle. "Can you picture a strong man sharing Taylor?"

"I don't know..."

"Do it. Picture it. Can you picture a guy strong enough, who shows no weakness, who could share her?"

"I guess..."

"What does he look like?"

"Not me," he laughed.

She smiled, reached and rubbed the back of his hand. "Be that guy. Picture it. Picture that guy. Can it be done? If it can be done, and you fucking know it can, then *be* that guy. *You* make yourself weak. Be strong. And you know what? It's not even really *strong*..."

"What is it?"

"Be smooth. Be smooth, Harrison."

"I'm the least smooth guy I know."

"Harrison, I'm going to be real. You are not the guy I grew up with. I can't believe you're the same guy."

"Is that good or bad?"

"That's good, buddy. I mean it, you're impressing the shit out of me. Impress the shit out of Taylor. Be that smooth strong dude who can do this."

"I gotta make some changes," he joked, rolling his eyes around.

"Make those changes."

"I need a new wardrobe. How does a smooth guy dress?"

"You're such an idiot."

"Tell me, Kay. What do I wear? Should my shirt be open? Tight pants?"

"You can do it. Seriously, look at me..."

He couldn't. He rubbed his hands over his face and dug the tips of his middle fingers into his eye sockets. Inhaled, exhaled, laughed. When he

took his hands away, his eyes were watering, but he leveled his gaze at Kelsey who watched him earnestly if not sternly, pink hair falling around her face.

She said, "You need Taylor. Taylor needs you. Make the change. Be what you need to be. For you. For her."

He fell forward heavily, arm flopping over their table so he could clutch at the sleeve of her leather jacket. "Are you my life coach?" He made a pathetic face for her benefit.

It made her smile, and she said, "I'll be your life coach," and played with his hair. Her eyes watched over him tenderly. "Confess your sins to your life coach, my son. Is there something else you want to tell me?"

He smiled, but it was a shield. They were just playing around, she didn't really want inside his darkest rooms. But the more she stared, the more he considered the things he wished to keep from her. But did she already know? Did Taylor tell her the worst of it? He thought back to watching Cole pound Taylor, making his girlfriend utter sounds he'd never heard before, all seen through a window he once spied her through when she'd just graduated to a training bra. An evolution had been witnessed through that Looking Glass, a graduation. Kid becomes girl becomes woman; all seen with his eyes, and just beyond his reach. The sight of Taylor being made a woman by Colt had him ejaculating in his pants. He said, "What all did she tell you?"

Kay toyed with a lock of his hair, her compassionate expression tightening into one of repressed glee. She chuckled. "She didn't tell me anything."

He frowned, watching his friend wince, wiggling her nose and showing her teeth. He stiffened. "Nothing about me watching?"

"She didn't tell me you were watching at all."

He bolted upright. "Are you fucking serious, Kay? Why would you do that?..." He pressed fists to his temples. "I'm so stupid."

"Yeah, you're stupid," she said and patted his cheek. "But you guys are assholes. If you lock me out, you don't think I'm going to sneak my way in another door?"

He was still bewildered. He covered his face again. "I can't believe I told you that. My God, Taylor's gonna fucking kill me."

"I can't believe she didn't warn you. I tricked her, too."

“You’re such a bitch,” he said, hating that she thought this was so funny after he’d confessed to her his sin. *But hadn’t she known it already?*...

“Tell me about it. But you know what?—I actually felt bad.”

“Not bad enough.”

“I *need* to know things.”

He rubbed his eyes and groaned. “Well, now you know.”

Kay balled up her burrito wrapper and tossed it at him. It bounced off his chest and fell in the grass. She beamed. “I feel better. Don’t you?...”

Chapter Two

TAYLOR

IT WAS the stupidest thing ever, but she couldn't stop thinking about it. It had her leg bouncing under the lecture hall table, had her hands smoothing over her hair in regular waves. Her heart raced.

She was in Economics of Accounting, the G auditorium, Thurman Hall, in the Westwood building, thirteen rows down from the top, center aisle, three chairs in. She had her laptop open, and her notepad out. But she could not concentrate on what Professor Dobbins was teaching.

Now she began to chew the inside of her lip, too. She pressed both hands down on her knees and still they bounced. She squeezed at her cotton sweatpants and focused as hard as she could.

Did she do it or didn't she?

It fucking sucked when you had to get to class so quick...

Her bed was made, she remembered that. Then sitting with its back against the pillow was her Harrison bear—Harry Bear, that's what she called him. He was snuggled up in his baby onesie, red with its black moosies. Angled slightly so he could look out the window while she was gone. Her ritual: one kiss on his lips, two on his heart. A nice odd number of three.

But had she done it when she left? Or was that yesterday?

She'd packed her bag, thrown it over her shoulder, ran into Lacy in the hallway just outside the door. Did the back-and-forth, fast-firing talk about meeting up later, maybe doing study group this evening. Then she was gone, racing down the hall. Did she kiss Harry Bear? It was so fucking stupid. But that was Harrison. That was her connection to him.

It's so stupid. You don't need to do it.

Do it and you can stop thinking about it.

It's good luck.

If you don't, Harrison will love some slut and she'll ruin his life. That bear's heart is Harrison's heart, and it needs to be kissed. Do it for Harrison...

Fuck.

She arched her back and squeezed her knees harder, turned her chin up to look at the dim fluorescent lights twenty feet above. Dobbins was saying something about equity financing.

Well, this was fucking pointless.

She closed her laptop, tucked it in her bag, slid her books over, put them away as well.

Now she sidled along, saying sorry and saying excuse me, then darting up the aisle to the exit. It was a quick sprint across McKenzie Field, then to her residence.

She met Makayla coming out of their dorm room.

"Hey," the girl said, eyes down, moving aside.

"Hey," Taylor said, trying to keep it upbeat. "What's up?"

Makayla moved to the right to get past her, and out of habit Taylor gave her way. Makayla left the room and headed down the hall. To her back, Taylor said, "Nothing. Where you going?"

"To class," she said without turning around, continuing down the hall.

Shit, Makayla passed on the *right* side. Traffic opposes on the left-hand side; this wasn't Britain.

She put one foot into the dorm room, but knew what had to be done.

Now she was darting back, racing down the hall to catch up with Makayla. She got ahead of her, came around her front then leaned her shoulder against the wall under a sheaf of paper with segmented phone numbers, someone trying to sell a bicycle.

Makayla looked at her with disdain. "What are you doing?"

"Nothing. I was wondering if you wanted to go out later."

"Go out where?"

"I don't know, I have study group."

"What class?"

"Entrepreneurship."

"I don't even take Economics."

“Or whatever...” Taylor shrugged.

Makayla raised her eyebrows, sighed with restrained exasperation. She said, “Yeah, or whatever. I gotta go get to class.”

“Okay,” Taylor said, relief flooding her systems now. Makayla passed on her left side and all was well and ordered in the world. She called after her, “Okay, I’ll catch you later.”

Makayla didn’t even wave. It was hard to pinpoint what she’d done to bother Makayla, but the girl had a problem, that was for sure. It didn’t matter now, because she felt much better. She returned to her room, found Harry Bear sitting where he should be, resting on her pillows and looking out the window.

“Hey, buddy,” she said.

She climbed up on her bed, brought Harry Bear close. She gave him a kiss on his lips, and two on his heart. Did it one more time just to be sure because if she had done it earlier she’d prefer it done three times rather than two.

Problem solved, she returned to class.

Thursday, September 13

Chapter Three

HARRISON

HARRISON ENVISIONED Kelsey's portrait of the strong man who could share Taylor as a man who lifted weights. That was pretty much for sure. He'd figure out the wardrobe later.

So now he was in Addison Hall, the Cooke-Johnson Sports Facility, heading into the change room. At home this morning he packed himself a pretty decent gym bag. Fingerless gloves, soccer shorts, cotton shirt, and Converse (because he read that's what you wear when you lift heavy weights). He got himself a locker, nodded to a guy heading for the showers next to him. The guy was pretty jacked, not huge, but he had a pretty bad ass tattoo on his shoulder blade. That was something to consider. He pictured a scorpion on his shoulder, but that made him think of Riley, and he swatted the image away. Would a guy who shared Taylor have a tattoo? Interesting. The guy *could* have a tattoo. But maybe he didn't *have* to have one. Used to be you were a man of mystery if you had a tattoo. Now fucking everybody had them. Maybe you were a man of mystery if you didn't have one. Like some kind of Zen thing. Maybe a religious thing. Like, Hey, I believe in such-and-such, we don't desecrate our bodies. That was kind of cool. You could pitch that to somebody and they'd listen.

Locker slammed shut, combination dial spun, he headed to the weight room with his printed-out sheet he'd swiped off the internet.

The gym was packed, place clanging with weights, huge guys there. Lots of scantily clad girls, too, bopping around in yoga pants and tank tops. Shit—something he forgot: Water bottle. Everybody here had a water

bottle. Mental note to add that to his shopping list—he'd stop on the way home and get one.

There was a clutch of some pretty masculine-looking guys chatting up a blonde girl with a ponytail, and he nodded politely and squeezed past them. That was when he stopped short.

A raucous laugh. A familiar one.

There, maybe just two dozen feet away, was the guy who'd fucked his girlfriend. That piece of shit motherfucker. His stomach turned right over and his knees went loose. He put his hand out and staggered to the right to hold on to the metal frame of a squat rack so he wouldn't fall over.

Colt, hat backwards, football T-shirt with the sleeves cut off. Flexing, laughing, talking up some brunette who obviously looked like she wanted to fuck him. What the fuck was he doing here? The football team had its own gym. This was his safe space. This should be a Colt-free zone. What were the chances this guy would be in this gym at the same fucking time as him? Shouldn't he be doing push-ups and fucking other guys' girlfriends on the other side of campus? Don't they have special quarters for that sort of thing? Couldn't Colt just leave him alone?

Then the dreaded moment. Colt's periphery caught the weirdo leaning against the squat rack like he would faint while staring at him. The worst part was when their gaze first met there was a glimmer of recognition in Colt's eyes, but the identity of the person who stared at him was eluded. It was like he knew Harrison, but couldn't quite place him.

Yeah, two weeks ago you tortured me, told me you're going to fuck my girlfriend like a threat, and then you did it. You fucked the most beautiful girl in Michigan, my best friend, the girl I love. You don't remember?

Then it all came back to Colt; he smiled, did that chin nod thing and looked away. The brunette girl turned to see who had her man's attention—*better not be some other yoga pant bimbo*—and when she saw it was some dumb kid wearing fingerless gloves whose cheeks were probably blazing red with fury and shame, she smiled again, tossed her ponytail and resumed with Colt.

Now there was nothing he could do. Was he going to stumble around with his dumb printout, do some dumbbell curls, strain through an unimpressive bench press?... Was he going to be able to do *any* of it with this guy here? The answer was no. It was no, and he knew it, and he was here to be a *better* person not to remember what a *lousy* person he was. Not

to be reminded that he was a guy who'd just watched this handsome piece of shit fuck his girlfriend.

He crumpled his printed workout and erased his mental inventory. No point buying a water bottle when you weren't coming back here again. The wad of paper was tossed into the trashcan, and he returned to the change room. All he wanted right now was to be back in high school and sitting with his friends, flash back six months ago when he was king. When his queen was his alone, and she was his best friend, and he thought he knew how everything would be.

Why did he think he could be the guy that would share her? That would take a strong man. And he was not. He ached for her.

He couldn't be strong for her. Taylor turned him to jelly.

MAYBE THE ONLY EXERCISE HE would get would be horsing laundry up from the basement to the second floor. Three loads down there that he had to take up in individual trips. Dried and folded, arranged in layers in tall plastic hampers, he brought them up to the appropriate rooms. Two in his parents' bedroom, this last one headed for his. At the top of the stairs, turning left, he paused at Heather's door. At one time her name had been affixed to it, sticky vinyl letters applied right to the paint. He wondered who ever removed them. Probably his dad.

No one was home, so he set the hamper down, turned the knob and went into his sister's room. Everything was as it should be. Everything in its place. A museum dedicated to Heather. Her bed with its floral quilt and matching bed skirt that touched the carpet. And the carpet with its fresh vacuum patchwork paths. His mother in here every other week probably going over the room that didn't need cleaning. Heather's posters hung on the wall, and heartbreaking framed photos of her friends on her dresser.

He shuffled in, wary of leaving footprints in the carpet, set himself down on the comfy upholstered chair in the closest corner of the room. Against the chair's back was a heart-shaped pillow, and he plucked it and held it in his lap, hugged it as he looked around the room. The place was pristine, and if it were to be a museum, it shouldn't be so. What about shoes that should be laying all over the place?... discarded jeans turned inside out, hats everywhere...? The only hat he could see now was the black beret she used to wear sitting on her dresser, its plucky apple stem still sticking up

after all these years. He brushed his hands over the heart-shaped pillow, running his fingertips around the pin buttons affixed to it. Wiz Khalifa, Major Lazer, Fetty Wap, a marijuana leaf, a hammer and sickle, and some musical incongruities like The Beatles, The Clash, and Ed Sheeran. She'd had a thing for buttons at one time. He'd bought her some of these; the old yellow Smiley Face one their dad said looked like it was from the 70s. He'd put that in her stocking with some gross-out candies from the joke shop on her last Christmas.

He ran a thumb over that happy yellow face now, tracing its smile with the edge of his fingernail.

There was a thunk outside, and it got him rising instantly. He pivoted, put the pillow back where it was, brushed his hands to smooth any wrinkles that might've formed where his ass had touched Heather's throne. Backed out, sweeping his foot to fluff up the carpet's pile, left the room and closed the door again. He brought the hamper to his bedroom and a few minutes later he could hear his mom coming up the stairs. She stopped at his doorway, well-dressed like she had an appointment with the principal or something (though those troubled days were gone), wearing a skirt and a shirt and jacket. She held her purse clutched in both hands at her stomach. She watched him solemnly as he put his folded laundry in drawers. She said, "You didn't get anything started for dinner?"

"I just got home," he told her.

"Just got home," she said absently, looking down the hall toward her bedroom door. She turned back said, "Were you hanging out with Kelsey Kay Miller?"

"No," he said. "I was at school. At class."

"Okay," she said, running her fingers over the curled brass lip of her clamshell opening purse. She said, "What do you want to do for dinner?"

He shrugged. "It's late," he said, "I think there's a frozen lasagna in the fridge. You want me to heat it up?"

She nodded, said, "Yeah, that would be good. I'm going to my room. Maybe have a bath."

"I'll get dinner started," he said, fishing out socks from the bottom of the hamper.

AT DINNER it was just the two of them, his dad probably not going to be home until after nine o'clock. He and his mother sat at the kitchen table, the two of them quiet, eating the microwaved frozen lasagna and the salad he made, clinking their forks. She had a glass of white wine and he had a short glass of milk. He asked her why she was dressed up today.

She picked through her lasagna, said, "Book club. In the afternoon I went over to the library where we meet. We talked about the book and then we went out for tea afterward at that gift shop up north."

"That's nice," he said.

"I hate the book," she said.

"That's too bad."

She shrugged. She looked pretty with her hair done up, cut short now, pinned back. Her hands had aged, he noticed. He could remember a time when they were smooth, but now he saw the wrinkles over her knuckles like a crocodile's back in pale miniature.

"I hope school is going well," she said.

"I'm working hard."

"Not up late playing video games?"

"Sometimes."

"You're at college now," she said morosely.

"Everybody at college plays games, Mom."

She did this thing with her eyebrows that showed him she had an argument but just didn't feel like getting into it. He supposed when she went to school there weren't video games. He thought to tell her that he'd gone by the gym to try to work out. Like just the act of going somehow deserved merit. But even if he *had* worked out, she wouldn't be impressed by it, would probably have something else to say that showed he was spending time doing things he shouldn't. But that wasn't playing video games, it was physical activity, something she often lamented he hadn't indulged enough. He left it unsaid.

When she was done, she wiped her mouth with a napkin, set it down on the table. She said, "I'll take care of the dishes, okay?"

He told her okay and pushed his plate forward.

"Thank you for dinner," she said, at least smiling now.

He told her she was welcome, and she said he should go and study. He took the remaining portion of lasagna and put it in Tupperware, sealed it,

and put it in the fridge for his father later when he got home, told his mother he'd be upstairs while she silently loaded the dishwasher.

Chapter Four

HARRISON

TAYLOR HADN'T ANSWERED his last text for two days. He called and left messages. She called him once, too, but he imagined she'd waited for a time when she knew it would go straight to voicemail.

But now his iPad was alive with an incoming call.

It was ten o'clock at night, it would be one o'clock in Santa Cruz, and he scrambled to answer the call. She would be the only one Skyping him right now and he knew it was her. And if she was Skyping, she wanted to talk, not just leave him a message.

He'd been getting ready for bed, teeth brushed, bedroom door closed, lights turned down low. His mom was already in bed, and dad was up watching TV in the study above his room.

He flipped open his iPad and sat on his bed, waited with his heart stopped in his chest. On his screen was a blank window, but the text description confirmed it: **Taylor calling...**

"Come on, come on," he said, and rubbed his palms on his thighs as he waited for the image to come alive.

...And there she was, her actual real-live face looking back at him. He put a hand over his mouth, so happy to see her. She was smiling, but her expression was pinched with hurt. He worried so much about her.

"Hey, baby," she said.

He moved his hand away, said, "Hey, Taylor, I miss you so much."

Her lips instantly pursed, and she made a funny little face. Her voice went croaky. "I miss you, too."

"I've been calling you."

"Sorry," she whimpered.

"It's okay. Is everything all right?"

She nodded, but he could tell it wasn't. He said, "Tell me."

She said, "How's everything at home?"

He leaned back in bed to sit against his wall, angled his iPad so she could see him. "Everything's great. You talk to Kelsey?"

She nodded. "I do."

He wanted to say *Why don't you talk to me?* but thought that would be a bad idea, an *un-smooth* idea.

She said, "Is everything good there?"

"Everything's fine, Taylor."

"How's your mom and your dad?"

"Everybody's great. How are you?"

"I don't know," she said quietly, her voice tight, and she shrugged her shoulders.

He said, "Is your roommate still being mean to you?"

She nodded and he could see her chin dimple.

"Where are you?"

"I'm in my room," she said, voice croaky. Her fingers came into view and she wiped at her cheek like she might cry. "Makayla went out."

He said, "It's okay, Taylor."

"It's not okay," she said. "She's so mean and I hate it here. Why did I come here?"

"Switch schools."

"I can't do that now," she said, almost mad at him.

"I know. Just hang in there."

"Why am I so stupid? Harrison, why am I so stupid?"

"You're not stupid, Taylor. Not stupid at all."

Taylor sniffed and wiped at her eyes again. She said, "She called me a stuck-up bitch."

"Who did?"

"Makayla."

"Your roommate called you a stuck-up bitch?"

"Not to my face. I overheard her."

"Well, that's her problem."

"No. It's *my* problem. I fucking hate her."

"Can you switch rooms?"

"I don't have time for *anything*. I can't *do* anything."

"Don't worry. Just avoid her. Where is she now?"

"She's out, I told you, out all night. I can't even call you when she's around."

That lightened him. Like there might be a reason that she was avoiding him other than she didn't care anymore.

"I'm glad you called."

"I am, too. Harrison, I hate it so much here..."

"Are you making new friends?"

"No. I don't even want new friends. I *have* friends. I hate her so much... why did I do this?..." He could see her shoulder jolt and knew she'd pounded her fist into the mattress.

He said, "Be strong, Taylor. Just call me anytime. I'm always here for you."

"I know," she croaked, wiped at her face again. "I miss you so much it hurts."

Now his heart pounded. "You do?"

"I miss you so, so, *so* much. Look," she said, and brought something in the frame with her. Cheek-to-cheek now with the bear he'd bought her, he saw that she'd put that baby onesie on it.

He started to laugh but realized she was in too sensitive a mood for that, and quickly said, "I love it."

She said, "I sleep with him every night."

"I'm glad." Then the bear was away, and she was just laying there with her eyes rolled up, not saying anything, just breathing.

He said, "I'll see you soon. I'll see you at Thanksgiving."

"It seems so far away," she said, ran her hand over her hair.

"It's not that long."

"How am I going to come back here after being home at Thanksgiving?"

"It'll be okay. How are classes?"

"Classes are fine. I can *do* classes."

"What is it? The dorm?"

"I hate it. There's so many people here and I don't know any of them."

"You'll get to know them, it's only been a few weeks."

"God," she scoffed. "I don't even *want* to know them."

He wanted to make a joke, wondering out loud to her how Makayla could call her a stuck-up bitch but it wouldn't be well-received. Instead, he said, "You've got to find *somebody* there."

"I talk to some people."

The first question was Are any of them guys? but he held that one at bay. He tried to envision this fictional character he was supposed to become. The guy that should lift weights but couldn't because there was a bully in the gym. Maybe he could handle this part better, though.

She said, "There's this one girl CJ, and this other girl Lacy. We go to study group together, but it's just because we're in the same class."

"She's in your dorm?"

"Yeah," she said, her face sullen again.

He said, "Well, *there's* a friend."

She shrugged. "I don't know."

"Give it time, Taylor. You're an amazing person, and you're so beautiful. How can you not have friends?"

"I know, right?" She shook her fist, and he saw her shoulder jolt again. Her eyes went red. "I just fucking hate Makayla so much. I hate her stupid face when she comes in here. She makes me feel so stupid."

"Don't let her make you feel like that."

"I can't help it."

"I wish I was there," he said, and it came out of him as an honest, helpless sigh. It made her lips wriggle.

She squeaked, "I wish you were here, too."

It broke his heart in two to see her in so much hurt like that, and to know it couldn't be solved. To know that if they weren't separated by 2,400 miles, he could throw his arms around her. If he were in Santa Cruz, she wouldn't cry. He would hold her, they would be friends, they would watch movies, and if she fell asleep on him, he would toss gummy bears at her face until she woke up. He said, "I'll see you soon. I will, I really will."

"I wish you were here," she said again and he could tell she was hugging that bear, could see the top of its ear in the frame.

He said again, "I just miss you so much."

She sobbed. "I m-miss you so-oh, so much, b-baby..."

"I wish you were here in my bedroom right now."

She said, "I wish I was, too. I wish I was so bad."

"We could cuddle up in my bed."

“I’d like that. Harrison, I *need* it...”

“We can watch Netflix on my iPad, mess around under the sheets...”

It got her giggling, though her face still looked like a girl that was crying. She said, “Yeah, I wish I was there so bad. I want it so much, Harrison.”

His heart was expanding so big it was about to burst out of his chest. He said, “I wish you were here, too. I *need* you.”

That got the giggle extinguished and the sad face was back. Her lips turned down, her chin dimpled. Even when she made an awful crying face, she was beautiful.

“I’d hold you under the sheets, I’d kiss your neck.”

She nodded, wanting to hear more.

“I’d kiss you all over, I wouldn’t let you hurt at all. I’d hold you and hug you and rub your back.”

Her eyes wavered on his. “Would you kiss me?”

“I would. I’d kiss you.”

“On my lips?”

“I’d kiss your lips, you couldn’t stop me from kissing your lips.”

“Are we in our pajamas?”

Instantly his eyes went wide. He knew what was happening here and he couldn’t believe it. “No, we took them off already.”

“Good,” she said.

“They were too hot.”

“Your dad keeps your house too warm.”

“Tell my mom about it.”

She said, “So we took our stuff off?”

He could hear her sliding around in bed. “Yeah, we took our stuff off and we’re naked.”

“What movie are we watching?”

He laughed. “I dunno. Ice Age.”

“Good, we’ve seen that one.”

“Yeah, we’ve seen it a bunch of times. But we’re letting it play so if anybody passes by the room they don’t get suspicious.”

“Why would they be suspicious?”

“If it was too quiet in my room, they’ll know what we’re doing.”

“Yeah?” she said in a breathy sigh that got his heart racing. His cock was getting hard. “What are we doing?”

“We’re not doing anything yet, but we’re just starting.”

“Am I rubbing my thighs up against yours?”

“Yeah, our legs are touching, we’re kissing, and I’ve got my hand just under your breasts.”

“Are you going to touch them?”

“I am, but I’m waiting for the moment to build.”

“It’s building,” she sighed, and the camera was jostling and fabric was slipping across fabric. He was sure she was taking her pajamas off or whatever she was wearing.

He didn’t wait, pushed his sweatpants down too. His cock was hard as steel right now.

She said, “Are our thighs touching?”

He said, “Yeah.”

She said, “When I put my hand down, am I going to find out you’re hard?”

“Yes, you are...”

“Show me.”

“What?” He laughed.

“Show me, Harrison, please...”

“Okay,” he said, eyes shifting side-to-side in his bedroom even though he was alone. He lifted the covers, angled his iPad’s camera to show her his erection.

She sighed when she saw it. His heart was pounding harder. She was excited to see his arousal. Everything was right in the world again. Everything was going to work out. She said, “You’re so hard...”

“You make me so hard.”

She said, “Turn up Ice Age, we’re going to get noisy...”

“We are?”

“We’re going to make some noises...”

“Okay,” he said, “I turned it up,” doing nothing except touching his penis. Her eyes were narrowing into a drowsy look. He said, “Are you touching yourself?”

“Yeah,” she gasped. “You do it, too.”

He was stroking himself, and he said, “I wish I was touching you. Pretend it’s my hand.”

“I am,” she said, nodding.

“I’m pretending it’s your hand...”

“I can’t believe how hard you are in my hand,” she said.

“Your hand feels so good, can I put my fingers inside you?”

“They already are...”

“You feel so good,” he sighed. “Let me look at you.” Now he lay on his back, held his iPad up over his face and they were looking into each other’s eyes. “Taylor, I love you so much.”

“I love you, too, Harrison. Pleasure me...”

“I am... stroke me faster...”

“How about that?” she said, and he could hear the slick sounds of Taylor’s fingers working through her own sex all the way in California. This was making her wet. This was honest. She really missed him, it was no joke. All the hurt of her not contacting him was washed away. She was too busy, she did have Makayla lurking, she truly loved him. She wanted to be intimate, and her body was a hundred percent in on the game. He could hear the juicy sounds of her pussy from thousands of miles away and it was wet for him.

“I want to be inside you, Taylor, I want to be inside you so bad...”

“Put it in me, quick, Harrison, I want you inside me...”

“Let me get on top of you,” he whispered. He watched her face now, saw her eyes closed, chin tilted up, lips snarling as she fingered herself and couldn’t believe he was lucky enough for this to be happening. “You ready?”

“Put it in me, Harrison, all the way, I want to take you so deep.”

“Oh, wow,” he moaned, eyes fluttering at her dirty words. “Here it comes...”

“Oh, I feel it,” she whispered, “Harrison, baby, you feel so good... I’ve missed you...”

“You’re so tight...”

“Fuck me, okay...?”

“Yeah, I’m fucking you, I’m fucking you deep and hard...”

“Ah, mm, fuck, oh, you feel so good, Harrison...”

He jerked himself slow then fast, then slowing again when he got too close. he could hear little whimpers in Taylor’s throat and the wet sounds of her fingers working her own sex over hard and fast. They’d never masturbated together like this. The whole thing was so wild and unexpected he half anticipated waking up jerking off alone, his iPad still in his book bag on his desk, the whole thing a dream...

Taylor made soft little quick gasps and her head rocked from side to side. Then she suddenly hitched, made a surprised *Oh!*, said, “Come with me, okay? Can we come together?”

“You’re gonna come?”

“Yeah, mm, I’m going to come...”

“Really?”

“Oh, yeah, uh-huh,” she said, mouth hanging open as she writhed on the sheets, telltale ripples of muscle movement in her shoulder showing how fast she was fingering herself.

She was thinking of him. Harrison. Not thinking of Brady or Stevie or big dick Colt, she was saying his name, she was connected to him; it swelled his heart in his chest; bright red love blossomed in his eyes and blurred his vision with heartbeat color. She was a comer now. Her come-cherry had been popped and now she knew how to do it. Now he could get her over her orgasm-obstacle from thousands of miles away. Yeah, Colt maybe stretched her out so her button was exposed but what-the-fuck-ever, his beautiful Taylor and he were simpatico and glory hallelujah she was going to come with him. His balls rolled in their bag, and his heart rate kicked up a gear. He smiled wide, his tongue tracing the incising line of his teeth. His belly fluttered and bounced, his sex-system suddenly went engorged and primed as his seminal fluids began flooding his discharge system. “I’m gonna come, Taylor, I’m gonna come,” he chanted in heavy pants, “come with me, come with me...”

“I’m gonna, oh, I’m gonna, mm, oh, Harrison, do it, do it deep in me, come in me...”

Her words cracked in his ears like a starter pistol and his semen exploded out of the gates. He grunted and bucked, made tight choking sounds as he ejaculated all up his stomach and chest. Taylor moaned and whined, and he watched her beautiful face through slitted eyes as her head twisted in the pillow—*she was fucking coming*. This was Taylor in orgasm and it was incredible. He still spurted and squeezed, crushed his slippery cock head and watched Taylor come in her dorm room so far away using her mind, her fingers, and his voice.

That beautiful face contorted and twisted as she got bent over by an orgasm. *Why wasn’t he recording this? God, she was incredible.*

After a full stretching of her features, she made a draggy croak then let out a chuffing exhale, curling forward and knocking her iPad into the

sheets. He saw her ceiling but heard her panting. His own breaths were desperate and hungry and his temples pounded with his heartbeat. He began a soft chuckle of disbelief. He watched and waited, listening to the love of his life breathing ragged after a huge orgasm and he couldn't be happier.

Maybe a full minute passed before he saw the camera's view swinging around before settling on her rosy-cheeked face.

"You're still there?" she laughed breathily.

"Still here," he panted, chuckling.

"Oh, my God, Harrison," she laughed, "oh, wow."

"Yeah, ha, I know..."

She asked him, "Did you come?"

"Did *I* come?... ha, oh, yeah, oh, I came. I *know* you came... that was crazy..."

"Show me," she whispered.

"My dick?"

"Your come."

"You don't believe me?"

"Yeah-hah," she chuckled slyly, then sort of bashful: "I just want to see it."

He moved his iPad so the camera showed the pearly stripes and puddles on his belly, and he wished to God he'd started working out a year ago so his come would be beaded up on his chiseled abs like how Taylor liked it on Brady's stomach. "You like that?"

"Oh, it's so hot," she sighed.

He moved the screen so he could see her face again and swore she was touching herself still. She looked sleepy and dreamy, her shoulder muscles flexing a little, and she let out a long satisfied groan and he'd never felt more fucking masculine in his life. "That was so hot, Taylor," he said, "You're the fucking hottest thing ever."

She made an odd cat-like purring, reacting to his words.

"You feel good?"

"Oh, my God, I'm going to sleep like a baby, Harrison."

"You wanna just go?"

Her eyes were closed, brows high, face happy. She moaned and nodded, said, "Sorry," then giggled.

"You need sleep, baby," he said, "it's good when you're stressed."

"Uh-huh," she said sleepily, and nodded again.

“So go, baby, go night-night and we’ll talk soon.”

“Good night, baby,” she said, eyes still closed, and she shuffled her Harry Bear into frame.

“Snuggle up,” he said.

“I love you,” she said, blindly fumbling to take the bear’s paw and wave to him.

“I love you. Take care, baby...”

“Good night, Harrison,” she whispered, then clumsily turned her iPad off.

He stared at the blank screen and laughed.

Maybe he could be that guy...

Connection

SEPTEMBER 15-16

Saturday, September 15

Chapter One

HARRISON

ONE XBOX 360; a copy of Red Dead Redemption; eleven trade paperbacks of Essential Amazing Spider-Man that collected every issue from '68 to '84, all in black and white; an old iPod and an old iPhone that both still worked... all came to \$334 from the Action Resale store by the mall. It was a start.

Harrison was sitting at the food court in the mall. On his orange plastic tray in front of him was a serving of ginger beef teriyaki, vegetable fried rice, two pollock-based California sushi rolls, a can of Coke, and a napkin. The exact same order he used to get when Taylor worked at Yummy Japan. It seemed so long ago. But that was a happy time. That was when they'd come together. She'd been working here back when they lost their virginity together. What a summer. An amazing time. This meal made him happy, and the cash in his pocket was going in a fund, and he knew the name of that fund.

While he ate, he watched across the sparsely populated food court at the two young girls currently working the YJ counter. He'd ordered from them, trying not to laugh at how they looked in their uniforms. It was the *same* fucking uniform Taylor had worn and, God, she'd looked amazing in it. Her cute little red apron, her red baseball cap with Yummy Japan printed across it. Her perfect face and that perfect smile. She was always so congenial. She bubbled it. She oozed it.

From the side: "Look at this fucking guy..."

He jolted.

Coming up to his table now was a familiar face. Good-looking guy, sort of a thick, wavy pompadour combed up off his forehead. Today he wore a suit and overcoat and sported a leather duffel bag slung over a shoulder. Brady. The other guy who'd fucked Taylor.

Brady smiled, said, "Holy shit, dude. What are you doing here?"

"Eating Japanese," he said.

"I see that," Brady said and plopped himself down on the opposite side of the table. "How you been?"

"Not too bad."

"How's Taylor?"

His stomach tightened. "She's good. Yeah, I guess she's good."

"No, dude, something go wrong?"

"No, we're good. I just miss her."

He snapped his fingers. "Oh shit, that's right. She was going like to California or something, right?"

"Santa Cruz."

Brady nodded, looked around the food court and put his fingers together then drew them far apart. "Long distance is a bitch, bro."

"Tell me about it."

Brady had something else to say but was reluctant. Still looking around, eyes scanning the people eating their lunches, he said, "How's Kelsey?"

"She's really good."

"She at State with you?"

"Yeah, I see her like every day. At least when I'm at school."

"Oh yeah, that's right. You commute or something."

"Yeah, Kay's in a dorm."

Brady showed more reluctance to say something. He chewed the corner of his mouth, said it anyway. "She seeing anybody?"

"No. Nobody. Says she's taking school seriously."

Brady nodded. He was happy with the answer, and it was funny to know that he might have some relief that Kelsey wasn't with anyone. He said, "Yeah, she's a smart one."

"You want me to say hi or something?"

"Better not."

For some reason, that made Harrison laugh. Maybe Brady didn't have the best connection with Kelsey but he knew her well enough. If Harrison had told her Brady said hi he tried to picture the reaction from Kelsey. It

wasn't good. A sort of scoffing sound, and an eye-rolling look of disgust. Then some quip, something like, *I'm surprised he could string a sentence together*. Now he was laughing harder.

Brady joined in laughing. "...What?"

Harrison shook his head. "No, I'm just agreeing with you. Probably best not to say anything."

Brady laughed too, shook *his* head and pushed a thumb into his eye. He groaned. "She's such a bitch."

Harrison laughed still, but said, "Hey, that's my friend."

"Sorry," Brady said.

Harrison added: "But, *yeah*, she's a bitch."

Brady beamed, slung his shoulder bag to rest on the floor and took a seat opposite Harrison. He put his elbows on the table, rubbed his neck and made a groaning sound. "She was good," he said.

"I know. I've known her a long time."

"Yeah, I think we're done, but we had a good thing."

"It's too bad," Harrison said, took his Coke and drained it. There was a California roll he wasn't going to finish and Brady had been eyeing it. He pushed his plate forward and Brady took it.

He plopped it in his mouth, said, "Oh, well, Harrison, that's life," while he chewed, then licked the pad of his thumb.

Harrison wiped his hands on his napkin, gathered the trash together on his tray. He said, "Hey, I just thought of something. Where do *you* work out?"

Chapter Two

TAYLOR

AS SHE MOVED through the dorm room hall, she kept her shoulder to the wall so no one would pass on her right side and wreck her evening.

But it'd already been ruined.

Makayla was going out tonight into the town to hang out with a bunch of her loud-ass friends at the amusement park. They all met at their dorm room, eleven girls crammed into that small space, all jabbering away and cackling while she was trying to read. She switched to Netflix, watching on her laptop with her earbuds in, but the girls were still so loud she couldn't even concentrate on the movie. Then one of them gets tired of standing and sits on the foot of her bed. The fact that Makayla didn't like Taylor was obvious, even to her friends, and that mindset transferred to them all, she was sure of it. Each of them shifting sidelong glances at her, talking in whispers and laughing. Purposeful disdain, and wielded like a weapon. So she got out of there.

But now where was she going to go? There'd been offers. CJ from study said there was a party in a dorm room over at building C. She *could* go there. But everything inside her still felt unsettled. It was homesickness twisting at her stomach. Any other Friday night like this back at home she could hang with Kay or Shelby or Roxie—and that was if she wasn't hanging with her best bud Harrison. They were at home, Kay and Harrison, and she was so far away. The distance between them was thousands of miles and it could sometimes feel like the tendrils that held her together with her friends were stretched thin enough to snap. And that frightened her. Wasn't that what she wanted, putting all this distance between them?

Sometimes she couldn't even tell what she wanted anymore. It would have been so much easier to stay at home, go to...

"Michigan!" A sharp male voice behind her; confident, bemused. She could see the guy's face in her mind's eye before she even turned—who else would shout out 'Michigan' down a dorm hall?

Sure enough, with her back slouched against the cinderblock, she tucked her hands in her front pockets, and rolled a casual look back down the hall, the way she'd come, and saw a tall guy doing his easy-going walk toward her. The guy who'd come into her dorm room and talked to her and her mother on moving day. Tripp Heavens, someone said his name was, and they'd had a few encounters, meeting each other in the hallways and him chin-nodding, giving her that peacock smile, saying, "What's up, Michigan?" Trying to get a rise from her. Then he'd do that thing where his eyes followed her and if she looked behind, she'd catch him letting her see him checking her out slyly. Of course, she was looking back at him, too, so you get what you deserve.

Now she waited for him to catch up, letting her eyebrows rise, showing him her dry face, letting her eyes go a little sleepy like this dorm thing was just old news and everything was a bother. When he got closer, she asked, "Why do you always call me Michigan?"

"That's where you're from," he said, still smiling and unflappable.

She dented one of her dimples with a half-smile, said, "Do I call you Smug Town?"

He frowned, stopped short. "How'd you know I was from there?"

He'd got her to laugh, and she hadn't expected it.

"Hey, look at you, I knew you weren't so tough," he said, closing the distance, keeping some space between them, about six feet, him leaning against the wall like she was.

"Smug Town was, like, the birthplace of skateboarding, wasn't it?"

"I still have my old Smug Town deck," he said coolly. "You're guessing I'm from California."

"I am. It's the tan."

"What if I'm from Florida?"

"Not enough tattoos."

"Not on my arms, but I've got snakes and crosses all over my back and chest."

“I stand corrected,” she said, still giving him the lazy eyes, but with a holdover smile from when he made her laugh.

“Nah,” he said, crossing his arms and laughing. “You got me. I’m from Cali. L.A.”

“I’m supposed to be impressed or something?”

“Ooh,” he said, giving her a frightened face. “There’s that chilly wind from the north again.”

She shook her head at him. He was a good kidder. She said, “So what do you want, anyway?”

“Saw you wandering the halls, I was worried you were sleep-walking, going all slow like that, leaning on the wall.”

“I’m wide awake.”

“What are you doing tonight?” A smile flashed, and he presented the question like someone who had something exciting in their cupped hands and they wanted you to ask if you could take a look.

“I’m wandering the halls because I don’t like my roommate and I’m waiting for her to take off so I can get my room back.”

“Makayla? Aw, she’s a sweetheart.”

“Oh great,” she said and rolled her eyes, folded her arms like him. “Another soldier in her army of tormentors.”

“I haven’t heard anybody say they don’t like you.”

“Well, that’s good.”

“You’re just *never* around.”

“I have to study.”

“You don’t like to have any fun?”

“Sure I do.”

“Good, so don’t go back to your room, come out to party.”

“I was going to head over to C,” she lied.

“Come out with me,” he said, giving her a warm smile that she didn’t mind. He was a really good-looking guy, blonde-haired and tanned, tall and lean.

She said, “You’re not going to C?”

“No, out to Pogonip.”

“Where’s that?”

“The woods,” he said, then as if he figured how creepy that sounded, added: “It’s not crazy, just a bunch of cool dudes.”

“All dudes?”

“Girls are dudes.”

“That’s California for you.”

“Come on out, it’s chill, but it’s fun. Music, dancing, some beers.”

“I don’t drink,” she told him.

“You don’t have to. What are you going to do, party at C Building, the COS coming every five minutes tell you you need to turn it down, bunch of Midwest nerds, no offense, sipping on pops and talking about Xbox?”

IN THE BED of a lifted pickup, she and Tripp and a guy called Hayward and Hayward’s girlfriend Chloe rode across campus, heading to the east side. Hayward seemed to know Tripp well, but they hadn’t gone to high school together. Chloe was also really friendly with him.

They’d come out of Fleming, and this stocky guy with a crazy beard and a mesh-back hat was crossing in front of them with keys in one hand and a milkshake or something in the other. Tripp was like, “Hey, Bug, take us out to Pogo in your truck,” and the guy was like, “Sure, man.”

Bug dropped them off at the edge of the parking lot where it met a shield of woods, and Tripp stood at the door, sneakers curved on the truck’s step-up, arms draped over the sill. They laughed and talked low and Bug smoked a cigarette while she huddled with her arms crossed near Hayward and Chloe who were also talking close and sweet. It made her miss Harrison more. If he were here, she would totally snuggle up to him and he would love it, too.

Bug drove off when Tripp jumped down, and he enjoined her, holding an arm out like he would clutch her but letting it drop as he got close and respecting her space. It encouraged her to move nearer to him, hands tucked in the pockets of her cozy sweatshirt. She’d not wanted to go back to her dorm room after Tripp invited her out because she didn’t want to find out that Makayla and her murder of bitches were still in her room. Tripp said what she was wearing was fine; it was the woods, and it was super-casual. So she was dressed in shorts, sweatshirt, and canvas sneakers, which was pretty much what Tripp wore as well.

So when Tripp got close, Hayward asked, “Which way?” and Tripp nodded his head toward a black gap in the trees, wider than the rest, and started walking. She went with him...

September 16

Chapter Three

HARRISON

THERE WAS an inescapable tightness ravishing the inside of Harrison's elbows. It ran along the inside of the bicep where it touched down into the tendons and joint of the elbow. He tried pressing his thumb in, but it brought no relief. Straightening his arm fully took concentration. Brady warned him it would be this way, said it was going to be from a buildup of lactic acid. Whatever it was, it fucking sucked.

Last night he'd gone with Brady after Brady's shift and met him at the gym where he worked out. It was a Pure NRGY over on Bay Road. Brady hooked him up with a guest pass. On Saturdays, Brady said he worked out alone, his gym buddies were usually just Monday to Friday. Told him he would go in on Saturdays for an intense hypertrophy workout where he just *wrecked* himself. It reminded him to behave himself on the weekends, he told Harrison, not drink too much, try to get healthy stuff in his body to repair it so he wouldn't feel like a bag of stretched out shit on Sunday. And Harrison got it, because when he woke this morning he felt stretched out and hurting. All up his lower back *ached*; a knot twisted in the center of his upper back; that lactic acid tightness in the crux of his elbows; and a generalized burning sensation raced his chest and shoulders. But it had been awesome.

Brady took him through a beginner workout, showed him what he should do, and they hung out in the gym for two hours. It had been weird hanging out with the guy since their union was such an odd and complicated one. Brady had dated Kelsey for a long time. Then during the wildest and most unexpected night of Harrison's teenage life, he and Brady

had engaged in a foursome with Kay and Taylor. Brady had put his penis *inside* Taylor. The idea had been maddening.

After they worked out, they ended up in the showers together, and he would dash sidelong glances to that thing between Brady's legs. He didn't have some huge dick like Colt did, wagging that sausage around on the beach that day playing football, but it still just looked... *big*. The most unshakable aspect was that Taylor had *been* with it. Not just with *Brady*, but with that phallic fleshy male part of him. The thing had grown aroused, lengthened, thickened, pushed up inside Harrison's most treasured being.

The fact was easy enough to avoid—Brady sure didn't seem to think about it. He was talking about cars and trucks, and all the ways he wanted his body to improve over the next year; talked about making money, talked about going away in winter and all the girls he was going to bang in Mexico. If Harrison didn't look at Brady's naked body, and just listened to the guy talk, he could sort of forget about the way in which he knew Brady.

The guy wasn't like any of his other friends, but he was a good guy. He seemed generous with his time and liked hanging out and shooting the shit. In fact, Brady said Hey, why don't you come out with us tonight, we're going down to Scratchy's...

There was nothing stopping him from going, but it felt intimidating. He'd said, "Nah, I have a paper I gotta write this weekend and I'm way behind on it."

Brady shrugged it off like it was no big deal, they got dressed and went their separate ways. Brady said give him a call next weekend. Maybe he would. Right now he was trying to calculate how much he could afford to spend on joining Pure NRGY. It seemed like such a waste of money when he could go to the gym at the college for free.

WHEN HE WAS up this morning and eating his breakfast, his mom gave him a list of things he had to grab in town. He ran those errands for her, driving down to True Value, out to Bed Bath & Beyond, and over to the Walmart. He was back at lunchtime, played Xbox for an hour before his dad came by his bedroom rapping on the doorjamb telling him to give the lawn one more cut before the leaves started to come down.

So in the afternoon he did yard work. Raking, running the rider around the yards, bagging up mulched leaves that had already started to flutter their

way down. And for dinner his dad barbecued chicken breasts while his mom made a salad. They had a wordless dinner on the picnic bench on the back deck. Now he was knee-deep in homework.

He'd kind of lied to Brady about having a term paper to do, but figured if he said he just had a bunch of reading, Brady would try to talk him out of it—tell him to read on the toilet whenever Harrison got a chance—and he wouldn't have a good way to defend himself. So now he was lying on his back, trying to keep his eyes open, reading the world's most boring book about the finances of the colonialists. When his iPad made its bubbling Skype chime, he almost threw his book to the foot of the bed. He jumped up and rolled onto an elbow. No one Skyped him except for one person. *God, and they just talked a few days ago.* She couldn't get enough. She wanted to jerk off again. He already felt a tightening across his stomach thinking about it, thinking about Taylor and that connection they'd made through their iPads three nights ago. She wanted more of him, and, God, did he want more of her.

His hands fumbled trying to fold open his iPad's sleeve, and he brought the screen to life, getting instantly into Skype. The call *was* from Taylor, and now his heart was hammering with excitement.

He answered the call, could see Taylor reclining on her dorm room bed, holding the iPad against the tops of her thighs, looking down her chest at him. She looked sleepy, but she was smiling.

When she'd first gone away, he feared she'd secretly been happy to have finally shaken him loose. It was why he suspected she'd gone to Santa Cruz in the first place. To get far away from him. And though she agreed to be open once she was there, she barely talked to him. But now, here she was calling him again, maybe looking for them both to use their hands on themselves. He couldn't help a wide smile as he said, "Hey, Taylor, hey, baby, I'm so glad you called."

"Hey, baby," she said. She wagged her fingers at him.

He waved back, settled onto his bed much like she was and rested his iPad in his lap. It was a good angle for his face. He said, "You alone?" meaning Makayla but not wanting to say the name out loud.

She nodded, said, "Makayla went out for drinks late. I hope she doesn't come back. Ever."

"You still not getting along?"

Taylor shook her head no and then wiped her nose. “She’s such a bitch,” she said.

“Stay out of each other’s faces.”

“Believe me, I’m trying.”

He told her that was good, and she obviously wanted the subject changed, asking him what he’d been up to. He opened his mouth as if to blurt out Hey, I went out lifting weights, but then he would have to say it was with Brady. Last thing he wanted was her to be thinking about Brady right now. The guy with the hot bodybuilder-body that she had ogled while Kelsey dated him, finally got to put her hands all over when she had sex with the guy while Harrison watched. Plus, the cool smooth guy that shared his girlfriend probably didn’t have to brag about the *one* time he went to the gym. *You can’t brag at all, you just make the results evident.* So he would play it cool: “Same old, same old. Shit around the house, Xbox, homework... How about you?”

“I’m just always studying or in class or in this stupid room.”

It made him feel bad for her. It must suck to have gone so far away. He could call up some of the guys from high school, he could call up someone to hang with—shit, he went out and lifted weights with Brady last night—or he could hang out with Kay, they would go out for a meal or whatever. Familiar faces. Taylor was nowhere, with no friends—though she should be making lots of them. She was bright and smart and friendly and so damn pretty. But here she was, stuck in a foreign place, studying all day and going to classes, and then when she got home she was tucked into a room with someone that didn’t like her. *How could someone not like Taylor? What was this girl’s problem?*

He said, “Aw, baby, cheer up. Have you tried going out? Aren’t there parties, and people to hang out with?” Then he was wondering why he would even say that. *Fuck, no, stay sequestered in your room, the world’s a scary place, just study and come home at Thanksgiving...*

“Yeah, I did. I went out last night.”

“You did?” He sounded bright, but he could feel a tightness across his chest. One look at her and every guy at this dorm room party would have instant hard-ons, sidling up to her, trying to get in her pants. It was just a fact. “You went out to a party on campus?”

“Sort of on-campus.”

“Was it at a bar or something?”

“No, it was like... I don’t know... in the woods.”

“A party in the woods?”

“Yeah, like forty or fifty people. There are woods here, like right at campus.”

All he could imagine was fifty young people out dancing, lights flashing against the trees, some kind of EDM festival, everyone popping ecstasy and making out, rolling around in the dirt. He’d gone silent, and he was chewing on his lower lip. He brightened, forced himself, said, “Sounds like a good time.”

She didn’t answer, only nodded and sucked on her lower lip. Her head turned from the camera and she looked around her room. They were both quiet a while and his stomach was churning watching her. At last, she faced him again, let her lip plop out, sniffed and wiped her nose, said, “Did you ever see a movie called Lost Boys?”

“I think maybe,” he told her, shifting in the sheets.

“It’s about a group of hot guys who are vampires or something.”

“Oh, wait, it’s in California, right? Takes place there...”

“Yeah, the house from the movie is just outside of campus.”

“That’s cool. I should watch it again.”

“It’s this big old creepy house, abandoned now, got this fence all around it with, like, three rows of barbed wire up top—”

“Uh-huh,” he said, urging her to continue while he got more comfortable, slinking under the sheets but keeping his face half-turned to his iPad.

“Inside it’s still got some furniture, but parts have been wrecked, like graffiti and stuff, probably why they put up the fence.”

“You were inside?”

“Yeah, we broke in last night.”

“You and who?—wait, you broke in, past the barbed wire and all?”

“Uh-huh, we found this section that was already cut open. Well, *he* did, I didn’t know it was there.”

This was where he stiffened. His legs even jumped under the sheets. *He?*

TAYLOR CONTINUED: “It was night and everything, no one was around, we slipped in this gap in the fence and we went and poked around.”

“You and who?”

“This guy I know here. He’s nice. You’d probably like him.”

“It was just two of you?”

“Uh-huh, this was later.”

“What do you mean? Like you went off with some guy?”

“He’s not *some* guy.”

Now he grunted, shifted uncomfortably in his bed, moved his face out of the camera’s eye and rubbed his brow with the points of his fingers. He mouthed a shouted but silent *Fuuuck!* then sniffed and returned to the screen. Taylor was looking away, totally oblivious to the devastation she’d just ignited across the country. Acting cool, he said, “So who is he?”

“He’s this guy from Fleming—”

“Your dorm?”

“Yeah, he’s—”

“This guy lives in the same building?”

“Uh-huh, same floor, too, but way on the other side of the building.”

“What’s his name?”

“Tripp.”

“That’s his real name?”

She chuckled a sweet sound. “You’re so funny,” she said.

“Tripp what?” He needed to research this guy.

“Uh, Tripp Heavens.”

“Oh, Lord,” he said, watching her, wanting to make her smile, adding, “Is he religious or something?”

“I don’t know,” she laughed, “Maybe.”

“Sounds like a youth counsellor at a Christian Camp. Hey, everybody, I’m Tripp, your best buddy for the next two weeks, let me show you to your awesome bunks...” He did Tripp’s voice in a squeaky clean enthusiastic-Christian tone. It got Taylor giggling and some golden warmth pushed out the tension that had gripped his heart picturing her sneaking into an old building in the night with some guy he didn’t know.

“You’re so funny,” she said softly, looking in his eyes, hers narrowed in long-lash slits, dreamy looking.

“So if he’s not *some* guy, Taylor,” he said, “who is he?”

“I don’t know how to describe him,” she said, stretching. “He’s Tripp. He’s super nice. Like, seriously, Harrison, if you were here, this guy would be your best friend, and I totally mean that.”

“Why do you say that?”

“He’s laid back, totally chill, funny, tall, he’s—”

“Tall?”

“Yeah, he’s pretty tall.”

“Why would I like that?”

“I don’t know. I thought I was describing him.”

“You were saying why this guy would be like my best friend or something, then you tell me he’s tall like that’s what I look for in a friend.”

She shifted her eyes up and to the right, not an eye roll, but definitely a sign her patience was being tested. He should back off, but right now his heart was pumping hate for some tall guy called Tripp Heavens who was sneaking into condemned buildings with his girlfriend.

“Harrison, I’m just saying he’s like us. He’s not scuzzy, he’s not weird, he’s like our friends in Saginaw.”

“*I’m* in Saginaw.”

“I *know* where you are,” she said. “Tripp is a really good guy who would fit in with us is all I’m saying. And I think he might be rich.”

His stomach tightened at the thought and his face pinched into a grimace he forced to relax so she wouldn’t see it. “Why’s that?”

“I think he has a Porsche.”

“Why do you think that? Did he tell you that?”

“His friend Hayward was saying—we were riding in the back of some other guy’s pickup—that it was too bad we weren’t taking Tripp’s ride.”

“Oh, Taylor, you shouldn’t be riding in pickup beds.”

“Why not?”

“It’s not safe...”

“We weren’t on the road or anything, this was just on campus.”

He shook his head because he couldn’t help it. Anger came up his back, but it was quashed with wet submission. He said, “So he set his friend up to make you think he has a Porsche?” He could picture Taylor in the bed of a pickup, two guys working some game on her to make her think this fucking asshole Tripp was God’s Gift, two good-looking guys who were trying to fuck every hot girl on campus.

“I don’t think so. It wasn’t like that.”

“What was it like?”

Her face went sullen. He realized she was imitating his demeanor. It was him who was making the mean mug, and she was absorbing his energy.

“Maybe I don’t want to talk about Tripp anymore.” Her voice was thick and quiet.

“No, tell me, Taylor.”

“I don’t want to.”

“Yes, you do, come on. Sorry, so this guy has a Porsche?”

“I didn’t see it or anything.” Her face was still tight, her pouting lips held pursed, chin dimpled.

“No, but you said you think he’s rich.”

“I don’t care if he’s rich, I just want you to know he’s not scummy. He’s really nice, Harrison. Like a really nice guy, everybody likes him, he’s not a liar.”

“I didn’t say he was a liar.”

She cocked her head to the side, her eyebrows high, looking up and away toward her ceiling. “I don’t want you to think this guy is a jerk.”

“Okay. I don’t.”

“He’s polite and kind; he was good to me.”

“I’m sure he was.” *I’m sure he fucking, fucking was...*

She added: “And his friend Hayward was there with his girlfriend.”

“Okay. It was just the four of you?”

“No, not all night. I just mean when we were in the pickup truck.” Her voice was a little stressed.

“Good, good, okay...”

“Well, whatever, anyway, that guy drove us out to the woods.”

When she was quiet for too long, he asked: “You didn’t go on any roads I thought?”

She made an exasperated sound. “I told you we didn’t. The woods are on campus.”

“I didn’t know you had woods *on* your campus.”

“Well, we don’t, but I mean, the campus ends at some woods, like a State Park or something.”

“That’s where this house from the movie was?”

“Right, but we weren’t going there, we weren’t going out to see some house from a movie.”

“Look, sorry, I’ll shut up. Just tell me what happened.”

“What do you mean ‘*what happened?*’”

“You’re telling me something happened.”

She took a deep breath. “Yeah, something happened.” Her eyes cast away to the side and her mouth went slim and firm.

He stared at this image of her on his iPad’s screen, the girl he was heartbreakingly in love with, so fucking far away. Twenty-four-hundred miles. She was in her dorm room, so separate from him, her face turned away because she couldn’t meet his eyes right now. He could see they trembled, see they were wet. *Something happened.* Oh, fucking God, something happened...

He cleared his throat. He spoke with a shaky voice: “What happened, Taylor?...”

Chapter Four

TAYLOR

LAST NIGHT

EVERYONE in the woods liked Tripp.

He was right; it wasn't some big wild function with a bunch of drunk girls hooting and grinding on a bunch of macho jerks. It was chill.

They'd wandered out in the dark, down beaten paths and across fields, disappearing then into the woods. The night was blue-black and starry and she could see underfoot while the four of them walked, soon becoming six then seven then eight as they picked up stragglers along the way. After a while they could hear faint music coming in strains between the towering redwoods.

There were maybe around forty people out there in a small clearing edged by tall trees; they gathered in little clutches, hanging out, drinking beer, and there was that weed-smell, too. Someone handed her a can of beer as she passed but were cool about it when she waved it off and put her hands back in her pockets. Hayward and Chloe split off from them, finding another group of black people they knew and it was just Tripp and some other guy called Craig who sounded all right but who she couldn't really see because Tripp never got the flashlight on the guy's face. Craig took off—he said he was heading back to campus—then Tripp took her to a bigger group who all welcomed her. They had lanterns, and she could see some familiar faces from class and from around the dorms. It was low key, no stress, and she found a lawn chair and kicked her feet up on a log. Tripp sat next to her, joining her in on conversations and making sure she was always

good. It was attentive and appreciated because she'd asked for him to watch out for her and he didn't act like it was a big deal, fawning over her and being clingy, or making it seem like a chore. Tripp was actually a cool guy and everyone seemed to know him. Every five minutes someone was coming close to him and talking near his ear like he had ongoing threads with all these people. She could see how it would happen because the way he treated her was with care and if he did that with everyone...?

Some people danced later on, like maybe an hour later, and the music got turned up but it wasn't a problem. Tripp disappeared for a while and she saw him later dancing with some girls. A couple of guys came and sat in Tripp's chair to talk to her.

They stayed in the woods for a couple hours, and Tripp was always around checking on her. When it got more raucous as some late-comers showed up, she nudged his arm and asked about Big Rock Hole. Some guy sitting in Tripp's chair earlier had said he'd been there all day, that the party started at the water, some tire-swing swim spot called Big Rock Hole. The guy said as it got dark they moved the party into the woods because Big Rock Hole was a heat-score—a spot that brought rangers looking for parties to bust up.

Tripp said, "You want to go check it out, see if there're people still there?"

She said sure, not because she wanted to, but because the party was picking up and the noise and voices were starting to close in on her. She told him she liked to be by water. Tripp said bye to some of his friends, said he was taking off, and they headed out of the gathering going northwest instead of south toward campus and the way they'd walked in. She asked him how long it took to get there and he said he didn't know but didn't figure it would be more than fifteen minutes.

Along the way, the two of them walking side by side in the dark, her with her hands in sweatshirt pockets, him with a flashlight sweeping ahead, he asked her finally what her situation was. She'd wondered if he was interested or what.

She said, "What situation?"

"You know... guy. Or girl or whatever. Do you see someone?"

She nodded in the dark. She said, "I have a boyfriend."

"Bummer," he said. "Lucky guy, though. Captain of the football team or some shit?"

“Ha, no. He goes to Michigan. He’s a regular guy.”

He said, “I had a girlfriend, but we ended it in the summer. She’s going to Paris, if you can believe it.”

“Wow.”

“Her parents are loaded. She got an internship at some fashion house. She’s going to spend a year there before she goes to school.”

“You still love her?”

“Huh? Carly? Oh, no way. We were pretty casual. I hope the best for her. She’s a smart girl.”

They stopped now as their trail came to an intersection, facing each other, and he pointed a finger to the trail leading to the right.

“Harrison and I are pretty casual now too.”

“That’s his name? Harrison?”

She nodded. “But...”

He shone the flashlight up under his chin, wriggled his eyebrows like he was getting somewhere, like she would reveal that they were close to breaking up. “Long distance is hard, huh?”

“It is, but me and Harrison are tight. Like *super* tight...”

He set the flashlight’s beam on the trail again and headed to the right, which she figured would sort of be south. She hoped he knew where he was going. He said, “That’s cool.”

“But we’re...” Now she wanted to laugh.

“You’re what?”

She hesitated, then went for it. “We’re, uh, *open*.”

He stopped again, and they faced each other. He asked, “Open how?”

She laughed, rolled her eyes up and leaned away, letting out a groan. “We’re *free*.”

“Free to...?” Tripp was smiling wide, liking what he was hearing. And she kind of liked telling him. This would be the first non-friend human being to hear of her and Harrison’s arrangement.

With a measure of confidence and maturity, she said, “Free to see other people.”

“Whoah, dude,” he laughed. “For real?”

“Uh-huh,” she said in time with a grand and slow head nod.

“That’s wild.”

“I know.”

“He’s okay with you doing that?”

“He is.”

“And you’re okay if he sees other girls at Michigan?”

“Not really, but yeah.”

He laughed and lightly thumped his knee with the flashlight, making the light jitter around their feet.

She said, “We love each other, but we have to be realistic.”

His eyes went wide with shock and a kind of admiration almost, and now she felt really good about opening up. “That’s *so* grown up,” he said.

“We’ve known each other a long time.”

“Uh-huh,” he said, urging her to start walking. They were descending now through the dark, the beam lighting the way. Tripp had moved closer to her side, and she didn’t move away. “So you’re free to have fun, enjoy yourself?”

“Do whatever I want,” she said, sensing him looking over and watching her profile...

Chapter Five

HARRISON

A TIGHTNESS WORMED through his brow and made his head ache. His jaw muscles were clamped and his breaths were shallow. The thought of his Taylor walking through the woods toward a destiny he knew would be terrible was rending his heart, squeezing it and pulling, trying to tear it into two pieces before it was stomped. He could picture her the way she appeared in the dark—he'd seen it himself so many times, walking in the woods, being in backyard parties, being out at the pool in the moonlight, could see what this fucking piece of shit Tripp would see. That shape of her, that slim silhouette, the sway of her hair, the way moonlight would trace the curve of her cheek and you could tell if you'd got her smiling.

"Did you get there? Big Black Rock?"

"Big Rock Hole," she corrected him and he said whatever, wishing now she'd never called him. He'd been prepared for this but it was only pretend. Now he knew he wasn't ready for this. Ready or not, he would listen because he was afraid of *not* knowing. If he didn't know, then he was separate. Apart.

She continued, "Yeah, so we walked these trails just following his flashlight—"

"You think that was smart? You don't even know the guy..."

"Everyone else knows him, they saw us going together, what's he going to do?"

"It's the woods at nighttime. Not just him, anybody. Charles Manson was in California."

"Harrison, it was fine."

“All right, so you go to this place with a tire swing or whatever...”

“Right, we get there and it’s deserted. We thought—or at least *I* thought—there’d be some other people there hanging out.”

“So it was just the two of you?”

Now her front teeth scraped along her lower lip and he knew this was the “What Happened.” She’d fucked this guy Tripp at some California swimming hole. He wanted to scream *How could you!* Wanted to wing his iPad across his bedroom and watch it imbed in the drywall like an oversized ninja star. Wanted to *end* this. His heart couldn’t take it. There was no way he could take this...

“Yeah, it was kind of nice, though, Harrison. The stars were out, and the moon, so it was bright. This place is like a swimming hole, you know? Like, it’s on the river, at this kind of bend or something with a beach and like a high part, kind of grassy. It’s a spot you would like. Like, when I saw it, I thought, Hey, this is a Harrison place.”

“Yeah, except I’m here in Michigan.”

Her humor faded and the slight tug of her lips that showed a smile loosened and she went sad and quiet again. “Is this the right thing?” When she asked, her face was turned, eyes down and sad. In that instant, seeing her solemn face that way, he could hear the words in his mind that could come next: *I think we should break up...* And that jolted him so hard it made his eyes swell with the threat of tears. Not from being jilted, but from honest, deep sadness. Taylor was his best friend, his lover, the only girl for him ever.

He ignored her question, moved on into sunnier territory, even brightening his voice when he said, “I’m glad you were thinking of me.”

The corner of her mouth tugged into the angle of a smile. He watched her blinking, begging for her to turn and face him again, begging her not to end it. She did, shifting in her bed, her chin coming around, her eyes lifting to watch his across digital distance and getting his heart soaring again. “I really did. I miss you, baby.”

“I miss you, Taylor. I love you.”

“I love you, too,” she said, and he could see her eyes take on a sudden shine. She wiped at them with the tips of two fingers.

“So what did you do there, just hang out?”

“Yeah. It was peaceful but kind of chilly, so we like hunkered down in the sand by the water and we talked.”

“Talked about what?” The tension had returned to his brow, and he had to squint to see the screen.

She said, “Talked about Michigan, talked about L.A.”

“That’s where he’s from?”

“Yeah, he was born there, grew up there. He said his dad works for a record company.”

“That’s cool.”

“I talked about you. A lot.”

“That’s sweet. Does he have a girlfriend?” *Please let him have a girlfriend...*

“No. He did, but they broke up because they weren’t going to be together at college.”

He made a funny croak, and it was like her words had thumped him in his belly.

Then as if realizing how that sounded, she smiled, said, “But he thought it was really cool that we’re open.”

He stifled another groan, stiffening in his bed and tightening all the muscles in his thighs until they cramped. “You told him that?”

“Sure, why not?”

“No, it’s good. So you just came out and told him we’re open?”

“He asked if I had a boyfriend. I said I did, that we’re old friends, like really tight, and how we’re open while we’re at school.”

Bet Tripp loved to hear that. “What else?”

“I don’t know,” she sighed, slinking around in her bed to get more comfortable. “School, music, how I liked to be in the water. I told him how I used to water-ski—”

“Does he surf or something?”

“No, he doesn’t. But he used to swim at high school, just not at college.”

“What, like a swim team?”

“Right.”

Then she was silent. Her eyes watched him for a long moment and he wondered what was up. Then they moved down as she fidgeted with something at her side. She was stalling. This is the part where they had sex...

But now he could see her shimmy something up to rest in her arm pit: the top fuzzy ear-curve of the bear he’d bought her. But her eyes were

reluctant to return to the screen.

He asked her: “What happened, Taylor?”

She drew a long breath, sighed a humming sound, said, “Uh, we went swimming.”

“Okay,” he said. “Is that my bear?”

“Harry Bear? Yeah,” she said, high and girlish, moving her camera so he could see the bear resting against her side. “We’re snuggling.”

God, he fucking ached to be with her, and he at once loved her and cherished her but cursed her for striking this divide between them. “You guys look very cute together.”

She made a little production of snuggling with Harry, wriggling her shoulders up and down and giving him a sleepy face and a wide smile.

He said, “So you went swimming together?”

“Yeah, we went in and swam and waded.”

“It’s not too cold?”

“It was like fifty-five degrees, the water felt warmer than the air.”

Then it occurred to him. “What were you wearing?”

She saw his frown and immediately cast her eyes away and it was all the answer he needed.

“You didn’t wear anything?”

She shook her head, doing that dimpled chin thing again.

“Fucking skinny-dipping?” He regretted the profanity, and he saw that she rolled her eyes a little at him. “Sorry, Taylor, sorry. And don’t roll your eyes at me...”

“Sorry,” she muttered.

“Well, like was this his idea?”

“No, it was mine. I wanted to go swimming.”

“You wanted to go naked?”

“No, Harrison, I just wanted to go swimming, and what else was I going to do, go in wearing my clothes?”

“No,” he agreed. He couldn’t fucking believe she’d gone skinny-dipping with this guy she hardly knew. But given how the party at Wolf Lake had gone he shouldn’t have been surprised at all.

Now they were both silent except for the sounds of their heavy breaths, him mad at her, her mad at him for being mad at her. They didn’t say anything for a while, but finally he asked: “Did you see him naked?”

“No. It wasn’t like that. We faced away, like just took our things off with our backs to each other.”

“Did he see *you* naked?”

“I don’t think he was looking.”

He laughed abruptly, and it made his lips blow a raspberry he hadn’t intended.

“It was dark, Harrison,” she said.

“You just said the stars were out, the moon, and how you could see so well...”

“Well, what does it matter anyway?” she said defiantly now, the venom slapping him across the face and reminding him she didn’t need to do this. Fuck, *he* didn’t need to do it. Neither of them maybe *should* do it. But it was being done, because the idea of not being with her killed him.

“It doesn’t matter,” he said quietly.

She watched him on her computer from thousands of miles away and he could hear her soft feminine breathing. She broke the silence. “It does matter, Harrison.”

“No, you’re right, it doesn’t matter. I just... he probably saw you naked.”

She made a huff of a laugh, said, “Why, you would have sneaked a peek?”

He chuckled, the sound of his laugh funny, even *feeling* funny through his swelled sinuses. “Probably,” he muttered.

Chapter Six

TAYLOR

LAST NIGHT

“WOW, it’s colder than I thought,” Tripp said, pulling off his sweatshirt and laying it over a waist-high boulder.

She said, “You think it’s too cold to go in?”

“Nah,” he said, “we’ll be fine once we’re under.”

“We don’t have any towels,” she said.

“We’ll figure it out,” he said, now pulling up his T-shirt. She watched the muscles of his back as he pulled his arms out, tossed it lightly on top of the sweatshirt.

Before he could turn around, she put her back to him, unbuttoned her shorts, pushed them down to her knees and stepped out of them. There was another boulder about a dozen feet away, and she moved over there, hiding in the shadows. It was her idea to go swimming, and she wondered why she even wanted to. It was just something fun to do, and maybe there *was* this weird tension. The two of them, two good-looking people getting along, the two of them nineteen-years-old and in the first year of college, sitting side-by-side on a beach with no one around. If she was watching this in a movie, the girl would lay back and the guy would get over top of her and they would kiss. But she didn’t want to do that. But she didn’t want to go home, either. So swimming seemed like a good diversion. She did love the water, so why not? *Hey, let’s go for a swim* seemed like a great idea. If they could just be grown-ups now about getting undressed in front of each other, everything would be cool.

She turned her back to him, pried off her sneakers with her toes, stood in the cold sand with her bare feet. She glanced over to make sure he wasn't watching and pulled off her sweatshirt and T-shirt. Tripp let his shorts drop, and she got a quick look at his cute ass. Trish wasn't kidding, the kid had a hot can. She looked away quick before she got caught.

Now she moved closer to the boulder, almost getting to the other side of it to block Tripp's view. She was hunched down because a leafy branch was spread out over her head, and now she was peeping at Tripp again. His back was to her, being polite and giving her space; she could see the black shape of his silhouette against the moonlight on the water. She unhitched her bra, pulled it off and tucked it underneath her sweatshirt. Thumbs went into her panties then, and she slid them down. Now she was completely naked. Tripp stood in the water up to his knees, looking out at the tree line on the other side. She covered her breasts with her hands, said, "What water is this?"

"San Lorenzo River," he said, raising his voice so he could be heard while he faced away from her. It was a good test, seeing how quick he would be to turn around given the chance. He passed.

So now she quick-stepped on the balls of her feet down to join him, coming up right behind him, getting close. She said, "Hey, it's not *too* cold."

"You don't think this is cold?" he said, chancing a glance over his shoulder at her.

She said, "I'm from—"

"Michigan," he finished. "That's right, this is like a Michigan hot tub."

She flicked a middle finger against the middle of his back and laughed.

He made a little jump, said, "You coming in?" And then not even waiting for an answer, he was trotting forward and leaping headfirst into the water.

She laughed again and knew not to hesitate—if she stood here any longer he would come up again, look at her naked front on. It wouldn't be the end of the world but she didn't want to give him the wrong idea, so she took two long strides as well, uncovered her breasts and dove into the water to join him.

It was surprisingly refreshing. Cold water throbbed over her warm underarms and between her legs, and she flutter kicked until she broke the surface, coming up and running her hands through her hair to clear her face.

She spun around until she saw him, just about twenty feet off. He let out a hoot, and she laughed, said, “Too cold for you?”

“I’m not going to embarrass myself and pretend it’s no big deal...”

“Oh,” she said, “you got some shrinkage?” And then wondered why she even said that. Why would you get naked with this guy but not really want to be naked with him and then talk about his penis shrinking in the cold? He laughed out loud, and she said, “It’s a Michigan thing...”

He said, “Are Michigan guys always shriveled up?”

“Hey, that’s enough talk about penises right now.”

“Like I wanted to,” he grumbled, and it made her laugh. “But I’m glad you saw it *before* I got in the water.”

“I didn’t see it,” she laughed.

“Hey, cool, no, I just mean I wouldn’t want you to see it now.”

“I wasn’t looking.”

“Sorry, I’m not hassling you.”

“I might have seen it out of the corner of my eye.”

“Well, you’re not allowed to do that when we get out.”

“Now I’m def going to peep it, tell everybody what I see.”

“Harsh,” he laughed. “That’s what you were like in Michigan? You one of those girls?”

“What girls?”

“You know. Bitches.”

“Oh, my God. What?”

“You know what I mean. You on the top, you run your crew?”

“No way. I *had* a crew—”

“Bunch of smoke shows...”

She gave him a wary eye though he probably wasn’t even looking her way, the two of them paddling around. “Anyway, we did all right. I wasn’t the prettiest.”

“Shit, Michigan’s where it’s at.”

“You don’t have pretty girls in California?”

“We do. They’re not like you, though.”

“And what’s that? How am I?”

“Mm, I don’t know,” he said, considering how he’d phrase it. “Like hot, yeah, and cool, but not like California cool.”

“What’s California cool?”

“Like a fake cool. You know? Mean to be mean. You’re like mean when you need to be.”

“When was I mean to you?”

“When I met you. But I deserved it. I was being a tool.”

“I don’t know. I was in a bad mood that day.”

“See, that’s Michigan.”

“What is?”

“Able to say it might have been you.”

“Yeah, it could have been me.”

“That’s what’s so great about you. Like I feel really comfortable around you.”

“Like you’re going to start farting now or something?”

That made him laugh hard enough it echoed around the redwoods. “I’m not doing that,” he said. “But you see what I mean? I feel like I’ve been your friend a long time.”

“Yeah, you’re pretty okay, too, I guess.”

“Thank you. Not what you thought when you first met me?”

“No, not really. Oh, hey, I remember—I remember when I was mean to you thinking you were the kind of guy who could take it.”

“You didn’t wound me.”

“My mom thought you were hot.”

“Your mom’s...”

“Don’t say it...”

“Seemed really nice.”

“She’s nice.”

“You get along?”

“She wants to be my friend all the time.”

They were quiet for a long while, just the sound of the rushing water at the shore and the occasional moan of traffic from far away. Both of them floated on their backs, looking up at the sky.

“Hey, look at that,” he said, and she could see his hand lifting from the water and pointing into the sky, heard that tinkling of water as it dripped from his wrist. “Orion with the Gemini twins, Castor and Pollux,” he said.

She fluttered her hands, pointed her shoulder toward him so they were side-by-side, just about two feet apart. This close, she was aware of how naked she was. How naked he was. His face, chest, shoulders, ribs crested the water. So did hers. She tucked her chin, glanced down. Her breasts were

bared, nipples hard bolts pointing up to the stars above. She hoped he didn't see that and presume it was arousal. She said, "It's cold."

He said, "You want to get out?"

"No," she said, "what's Orion?"

"A constellation some people can use for navigation."

She turned, looked at his profile as he was watching the stars. She said, "Were you a Boy Scout?"

He laughed. "No, when I was little I was really into astronomy. My dad got me this telescope, I used to record everything I saw. When I got older, we even built this mini observatory."

"In L.A.?"

"No, we have this other place up north—well north of L.A., east of here. Property in Three Rivers, up by Sequoia."

"It's quiet there?"

"And dark," he said. "You need it to be dark, like, look at all this light bleeding from Santa Cruz," he said waving his hand out near their feet. There was a brownish corona to the sky that made the jagged points of redwoods sharp-edged.

She asked him, "You like it here? Santa Cruz?"

He put his hand down, paddled, and now they were much closer. He said, "Yeah. Of course I do. It's a lot of fun. You been down to the boardwalk yet?"

"No," she said.

"Dude, we should totally go."

"What you do there?"

"What, you making an itinerary? There's lots of stuff to do, we just go, we figure it out."

"You don't like to make plans?"

"Plans, sure, like we go to the boardwalk. But sometimes the fun stuff is what you didn't see coming."

She bit her lower lip, sneaked a look at his bare body. Mr. Laid-Back, Mr. No-Problem. Fluttering at her side, both of them like weightless little things floating through space. She could see how the moonlight lit his lean, wet muscle. He had a good body, she could tell. She sneaked a little peep while they were undressing. He had the kind of body she liked. Tall, long and lean, long legs. Ropey kind of guy, and he had big hands too, and she liked big hands. Super-cute butt, tight and round...

She looked down now, saw the moonlight winking hazy stars on the wet points of her nipples, she wondered if he liked what he saw...

Chapter Seven

HARRISON

HARRISON CLEARED his throat when she grew distant all of a sudden and stopped talking. Her eyes looked far away as though she were picturing it all over again. Her handsome tall guy called Tripp who was rich, from L.A., and had a dad who was a record executive. This fucking asshole trying to get into his girlfriend's pants. *Maybe did get in her pants...*

He said, "Did something happen there?"

"In the water? No..."

She was quiet again, her eyes more focused but still looking off to the side.

He said, "But something happened?"

She rolled her head on the pillow, said, "How do you want me to tell this?"

"What did we agree on?"

"That I would tell you the truth."

"So just tell me the truth, Taylor. There's nothing wrong."

"You going to be mad?"

"Why? What happened?..."

"It's not just that, Harrison. You're going to be mad no matter what. Look at all the things you're saying, and I was just talking about going out into the woods with him."

"I want this to work out, Taylor," he said earnestly. "I really do. It's just like we said, you would tell me what you did and it would be okay."

"So don't be mad at me, okay?"

"I don't want to be mad..."

"I'm careful, Harrison. I know about Charles Manson, I know about getting roofied, and I know about going off with a guy I hardly know, okay? But I'm not stupid, so don't make me feel like I'm stupid..."

"I don't think you're stupid at all, Taylor."

"Okay, so if I did something that sounds crazy you'll just let it go?"

"Within reason," he said.

She chuckled, rubbed her nose. "Yeah, within reason, that makes sense." She looked around her room a moment, thinking. "I'm not even drinking or anything."

"I'm not, either. Kay won't let me."

"Yeah, me too. She won't let me, either."

"So you weren't drinking?"

"Last night? No, not at all, I told you. I haven't had *any* drinks. I've been studying like crazy."

"That's good," he said—but he felt like the train had jumped the track here. He said, "So nothing happened there? You know, when you were skinny-dipping?"

She shook her head no. "No, it didn't."

"So you guys just swam around for a bit?"

"Yeah," she said, getting a little higher on the bed and propping herself up on a pillow. She looked at him with narrowed eyes, chewing on her lip again.

"What...?"

"How much do you want to know?"

Oh, gosh, it was bad.

"I want to know everything."

"What's everything?"

"Good question," he said. And here was his chance to escape the hurt. Here was his chance to say You know what, maybe it's better if you just say something happened and I didn't ask questions. *Hey, do you mean you slept with him?* Then she could say Yeah, and he could swallow that bile down and grit his teeth and move on with his day. But something in him didn't want it that way. Something in him wanted the hurt because the hurt was love. The hurt was *togetherness*. The hurt was because two people loved each other so much they could get over it. He said, "I watched you. You know, at Wolf Lake."

"You did," she said, and bit her lower lip.

“So if I watched it, I can hear about it, too. Like I mean *everything*.”

“You want to hear everything?”

He nodded because saying the words was too hard.

“Everything, Harrison?”

“Everything, Taylor. Look, I love you...”

“I love you, too, I love you so much, Harrison. You know that, right?”

“I do. I really do.”

“So if I tell you something that’s bad you’re not going to think I’m mean?”

“We agreed it was going to be this way, Taylor.”

She looked at him warily, swiveled her head around to get more comfortable on her pillow, watching him closely. She said, “We got out of the water and we dried off.”

“Dried off how?”

She said, “We came out, we stood around for a bit shivering until we couldn’t stand it. Then Tripp said that we should do jumping jacks to air dry, and we did that, too.”

“Facing each other?”

She shrugged, said, “No, that’s weird, Harrison.”

“Sorry,” he said. “Go on...”

“No, we were like apart, facing away from each other, and I didn’t really do them, I just jumped around a little bit. We ran a little, like on the beach a bit...”

“Uh-huh.”

“And like we were *still* wet, so we used his sweatshirt.”

“You dried yourself using his sweatshirt?”

“Yeah, it’s pretty big.”

“Because he’s tall,” he said petulantly.

She rolled her eyes. “I just mean it’s a man’s sweatshirt, Harrison.”

“I didn’t mean anything by it.”

There was that wary eye from her again, and she licked at her top lip. She said, “See? He’s nice. He let me dry the rest of myself on his sweatshirt, you know, inside out. Then I got dressed, he dried himself off, got dressed too.”

“Then what?”

“Well, like he tied the sweatshirt around his waist—”

“Yeah, yeah, after that...”

She shook her head, said, “We hiked out of there. There’s a parking lot, like a trailhead, not far from the swimming hole, so we walked through the woods a bit, came out there. There were some guys he knew hanging out in the parking lot.”

“Were they drinking?”

She shrugged, said, “They smelled like weed. Anyway, Tripp said for them to give us a ride back into town.”

“I hope they weren’t drinking...”

She said, “So this guy we go with, he’s kind of a stoner, maybe twenty-one, and we got in his old beat up Jeep, and he drove us down the road like seriously not even like five minutes, Harrison, and then Tripp was saying, like Oh, hey, pull over here...”

“Pull over where?”

“It’s just like this narrow road in the woods, and this guy pulls over and it’s not even a shoulder. And the guy, the stoner guy who has the Jeep, says, ‘Hey, you going to go to the clubhouse?’”

“What’s the clubhouse?”

“That’s that place where they shot this movie *Lost Boys*.”

So this was where it happened. Whatever happened meant.

“Oh,” he said, feeling sickly.

She could see it in his face, and her brow furrowed as if she were sad. She said, “I can stop here, Harrison.”

“I don’t want you to stop.”

“Are you sure?”

He wanted to ask Just tell me what you did—jump to the last shootout in the script. *Tell me how this thing ends*. But something stopped him from doing that, some weird pleasure he was getting out of having his most vulnerable part being stretched thin, twisted and twisted until it seeped bright blood. He said, “Tell me everything, I want to hear it.”

“Okay,” she said, taking a break, thinking about it, continuing, “so we get out of the Jeep, Tripp helps me out, and then the guy drives off. So we’re just standing on this road, and I don’t know anything about this *Lost Boy*’s house, and he says, you know, follow me, and he’s smiling like this is going to be fun, so I follow him. We just walk straight off the road, we start climbing this hill, and there’s like brush everywhere and I got little cuts on my arms. I’m kind of mad, saying, ‘Where are you taking me? Like where is this going? What’s a clubhouse? Why are we even doing this?’”

“I know how you can get,” he said.

That made her smile, and she said, “Well that’s how I was.”

“Poor guy,” he said.

“Shut up, Harrison,” she said comically, took the point of her index finger and blotted it in the middle of her camera like she was closing off.

“Hey,” he shouted, “sorry, come on...”

She removed her finger, gave a look of compassion. She said, “So after a bit, we get up really high, and we can look down. We can see the city of Santa Cruz, you know, see like the boardwalk and everything, the rollercoaster, but behind us now he turns me around and I see this huge old house with like a big wraparound porch and everything...”

“Yeah?”

“But it’s all surrounded by the fence I was talking about.”

“And this is the clubhouse, the Lost Boy’s house?”

“Yeah, but I don’t know anything about it. Tripp says Come on let’s go. I follow him, we go around the back, I asked him what he’s looking for. He says there’s like a gap in the fence that some guys cut, some older students.”

He said, “Bunch of vandals, cutting into a fence like that.”

“I know, right? And he said it wasn’t even like jocks or something, he said it was a bunch of D&D nerds.”

“Vampire nerds,” he said.

She giggled. “Yeah, vampire nerds. So we’re going along the fence and like kicking at it, we find this opening and we squeeze in, climbing up this back step near the far side of the house, you know the side away from the city...”

“What if you got caught?”

“I know, it was stupid, but it was just... we were just having fun...”

“I bet you could get arrested, like even suspended or expelled.”

Maybe that was for the better. Maybe let her get arrested, sent back home where he could keep her close.

“I know, well... maybe this is one of those things where you can say that I did something stupid...”

“Seriously, what if you got arrested?...” He wanted to strike fear in her.

“I know,” she said solemnly.

“So you went inside?”

“Well... there’s all these signs for like alarm systems—”

“Holy shit...”

“I know, Harrison, I know...”

“So you go in?”

“Yeah, he said one of those guys had taken off one of the plywood sheets—all the windows are boarded up—and it went into this back room...”

“You’re crazy...”

“Tripp went in first, turned around and you know, he helped me to climb in with him...”

Chapter Eight

TAYLOR

LAST NIGHT

TRIPP'S big hand closed around hers. It was gentle but strong, and she liked the feeling of it gripped on her. It was something about his manner that made her think he was genuinely concerned about her feeling protected. He was ahead of her, holding her hand, and she kept close behind him, letting her other hand rest in the middle of his back now as they stopped to peer from a small room that may have been a kitchen at one time (though all the appliances and cabinetry had been removed).

She whispered, "I swear to God, Tripp, if I see a mouse or oh, my God, a *rat*, I am so fucking out of here."

He laughed, said, "Me too."

"Or like even a raccoon," she said.

He laughed, said, "How about a possum?"

She scratched his palm with her fingernails in a ticklish manner, said, "Those are actually kinda cute."

"You stay around for a possum?"

"I might."

"I think one of those things would still scratch your eyes out, even if they are cute."

"Oh, my God, could you imagine if there was a *vampire* here?"

He laughed, brought her closer so she could peek around the corner with him, he said, "The vampires were movie ones, but there *is* supposed to be a ghost..."

“Would you fuck off,” she said, squirming out of his grip.

He said, “No, not here,” laughing, “out in the fields or something, maybe not even at the clubhouse. But like the grounds or something.”

“Why do they call this place a clubhouse?” Now she was looking around what would’ve been the entranceway as you would come in the main door. It looked like an old lodge, which was *so* weird because they weren’t even that far from the city.

He said, “Used to be a golf club, if you can believe it.”

“Where was the golf course?”

“I dunno. I guess there was a golf course here,” and he pointed out toward the front windows. One of the boards had been taken down, and she wondered if they would have been able to come in that way, right through the front.

Standing in the edge of light that came in the window, right at the mouth that opened out to the lobby, she said, “Can we go out in that room?”

“Why not?”

“The alarm sign. What if there’s like motion detectors?...”

He shook his head, said, “No, I know this guy in third year whose uncle is working on the restoration of this place.”

“Oh, yeah?”

“He says the alarms are bogus.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah, I heard those guys who cut the fence went up and all through this place for hours and no cops or rangers came.”

“It *is* pretty great,” she said now, looking around this creepy place where Tripp just told her they once shot a vampire movie. It had a rustic charm, and it didn’t even remind her of California, it reminded her of Michigan with roughhewn log support beams and cedar paneling. It looked like something you’d see up north at Wolf Lake. “It reminds me of home.”

“The logs, right? It doesn’t even *look* like California. Whoever built the golf course, I bet they were from up north.”

“I bet,” she said, and now she moved ahead of him, wanting to show she was brave. She let her hand slip from his, walked out into the lobby area.

She went near the front doors and looked out the window. Way in the distance she could see twinkling lights from down the boardwalk. She said, “Crazy view.”

Tripp came close behind her, put his hand in the middle of her back. It was nice, not presumptuous, almost friendly. Then he let it slide down, and stepped forward, moving toward the window. The place had been removed of furniture, but there was a messy enclave of discarded items she imagined would be headed for the dump. Tables, some of them on their sides, dining room suite furniture that didn't look like it would support you, and up against the window was a long leather couch with its support posts made from lumber with the bark still on it.

She said, "I can't believe someone hasn't stolen this couch."

"I bet you they tried, and it was full of rats."

She took a step back. "You think there're rats in it?"

He said, "I bet you that thing is like rat Manhattan," then stepped forward and kicked it with his toe. She took another step back. They waited, and there were no squeaks of vermin and Tripp stepped forward again and kicked it harder. He jumped back.

That got her laughing. She said, "No rats in there."

"Want to sit on it?"

"You first," she said.

She watched him as he tossed his sweatshirt onto it, then the flashlight thumping on top. They'd kept the beam off so they wouldn't give themselves away to any rangers who might be driving by. He put his knees on the couch seat, elbows over the couch's back, leaning on it so he could look out the window at the view.

No rats emerged, no mice, no raccoons, or possum, so now she joined him, putting her knees up, getting side-by-side with her elbows next to his and looking at the view. They watched out over Santa Cruz for a while, both of them quiet and taking in the spectacle. It was peaceful and cozy and yet swirling with a hint of danger. She was with a good-looking guy and he was a decent person, she didn't feel at all like she should be wary of him. In fact, she felt the other way: he made her feel safe. She said, "What are you going to do when you get outta here?"

"Out of this house?"

"Out of Santa Cruz."

He said, "I'm not sure. These last couple weeks I was thinking about maybe taking a focus on journalism."

"You want to be a journalist?"

"I think it's important."

"It is important," she said. "You work at your school paper or anything?"

He shook his head, said, "No, not at all. Never interested me when I was there, but for whatever reason, I just find myself drawn to it."

"You got four years to figure it out."

"I do. How about you? What are you going to do?"

"No idea at all." She sighed, stroked her hair away from her face.

"That's okay," he said. "So what did you come for here?"

"Business," she said. "And surfing," she added.

"Business and surfing, girl from Michigan," he said quietly, then slumped down to sit on his heels, one elbow over the back still, his cheek in the cup of his palm.

She imitated him, slumping down to sit like he did, their knees touching, and looking at each other's faces lit up by the star and city lights.

She said, "I don't know why I came to Santa Cruz. For real."

"You wanted to go surfing."

"I do, but it's not that."

"What is it?..."

She shook her head. "I can't even figure it out."

"Why are you so quiet around the dorm? You're hardly ever around..."

"Sometimes—no, *mostly*—I just want to be alone."

"I get that," he said. She felt a wave of compassionate understanding from him. Like he actually cared about her and why she was here. Not some guy trying to get in her pants, but this really neat and interesting guy—no, a *man*. At least an emerging man. He was charming and confident. Tall, good-looking, and her kind of guy with his long lean body and big hands. She watched him as he looked around the lobby of the old place, watched the way the tendons in his neck worked, the muscles of his jaw, the sharp angle of it, the curls of his sun-highlighted hair. When he turned back, she moved closer and his chin ducked down as if he wanted to be sure he was seeing what he was seeing. He moved a little closer, and then she did too, putting her hand on his thigh then letting it migrate upward onto his chest, feeling the hardness of his body under the cotton T-shirt. Their mouths came together, and she kissed him more than he kissed her. But he was eager, he was into it. His lips were soft and pillowy, and he smelled so good. Lots of things there, maybe some kind of soapy Speed Stick, some woodsy aftershave, maybe, but mostly she smelled outdoors on him, pine and river

water, and his own masculine smell. Soon their kisses grew more pronounced, and she moved her hand up to his neck. He did the same, curling his fingers around the back of her neck, his thumb stroking at her ear.

The room was quiet except for the sounds of their breath scoring through their nostrils. Soft moans began, and when Tripp broke away for a moment he said, "You good?" looking in her eyes.

She nodded quickly, licked at her own lips, could feel them swollen and excited. She pulled her wet hair away from her face and looked deeper in his eyes. He brought her back for another kiss, and she moved closer to him, rising up on her knees so she was over top of him. His hand went down her side and it got her stomach fluttering. But when it came around to the front to cup her breast in her bra, she put her hand over top of his and grunted an *Unh-unh* in her throat while they still kissed.

He respected it, bringing his hand back now resting at the low of her back. They made out for a good long while until her heart was pounding in her ears. She pulled back for a moment, wanting to take a break, settling back with her rump on her heels and smiling at him. He was smiling back at her.

He said, "You should see how beautiful you look in this light."

She looked away, bashful, and tsk-ed him. "Come on," she said.

"Whatever," he said, "I'll keep it to myself."

She looked back, said, "You don't have to."

"Come here," he said, winding his fingers through her sweatshirt at her hip and tugging on her to return. She did, getting over top of him again, this time laying her chest against his chest, letting him sink back on the old dusty couch, their mouths locked together. Now her heart was like a drum solo in her ears, and her breaths were coming faster. She squeezed at his muscles through his shirt, could feel the hard curve of his chest, could feel how slim he was, could feel the ridges of his ribs. She pulled up on his T-shirt, put a hand underneath it. He told her how warm her hands were.

She said, "You're cold?"

"I'm warming up," he said, and took her kiss back.

Soon she was moaning, grinding her body against his, her hand still under his shirt, her thumb flicking at his nipple. He let his other hand slip around like it wanted to come to her front again, and she pinched it under her underarm. He respected that too, pushed his hand around to the back.

They kissed some more, took a break again, said nothing, but looked in each other's eyes, both of them smiling. Then they made out some more, took another break, watched out at the stars. By the time their mouths came together again she was sure she wanted a little *more*. She let her hand explore. It went under his shirt again, feeling the flat of his stomach, slipping a little into his waistband, feeling the ridge of his hip bone. She patted her palm around until she found his hardness under his cotton shorts. He groaned in her mouth when she pressed down on it. They kissed, and she traced her fingers over it, outlining its shape under the cotton...

Chapter Nine

HARRISON

TENSION WAS SQUEEZING AT HIM, pulling all his joints and muscles, making him squirm in the bed trying to find relief. She was telling him everything. Telling him how she touched another guy. And despite the hurt in his heart, despite every jangling red-light clanging and banging, crossing-arms coming down to warn of an oncoming train, he still wanted to hear more. *And his own cock was hard.* As hard as Tripp's was last night for sure, making out with his girlfriend in the Lost Boys house. His stomach ached, he felt nauseous but *full* of lust. An erotic worm-drive pushing him further and further into places he was afraid he wanted to go.

His voice was dry, crackly. "You touched him?"

"I did," she said.

He didn't know what to say, his face poised as if he would ask a follow-up question but nothing came. He couldn't look at her, looked instead at just the power button on the bottom of his iPad.

She said, "You okay? I don't have to do this."

"No, you do. And I'm good, I'm good." He put a hand down and squeezed his erection through his pajama pants. Did it where she couldn't see, squeezing himself and gaining the strength to look in her eyes again. He looked at her, his sweet Taylor, his best friend since they were little, the love of his life and his girlfriend the last two-and-a-half years. It wasn't as bad as he thought looking at her. He thought he would see laser beams and hellfire shooting out of that evil face. But all he saw was that girl he loved. Saw the trepidation she had, saw the concern she had for him. She didn't have to tell him but she would if he wanted. It was him that was making her

do this. It wasn't her desire to let him know the terrible things she did, but she was willing to if he asked. He felt suddenly warm about her and managed a smile.

"You're smiling," she said brightly.

"I love you," he said.

"I know, I love you too."

"It's okay. Yeah, all right, so then what happened?"

"Well, like I said, I was kind of getting into it. He wasn't making me do this, Harrison. You understand? I told you you would like this guy. He's not like some..." She waved her hand around trying to come up with the word.

He said, "Colt."

She winced, then softly said, "No, he's not like Colt."

"So tell me what happened."

"We just kept kissing for a while, and I was like feeling him over his pants."

"Did he touch you?"

"He tried again, but I felt kinda weird about it..."

"That's okay. You don't have to do anything."

"And he didn't make me, you know, and that's what I really liked."

"What do you mean?"

"I'm making out with this guy, and I'm, you know, touching his..." She looked around funny for a second, said, "dick," quietly, then continued, "through his pants, and he's like really... well, you know..."

"Hard?"

"Yeah, he's really hard. But he's not, you know, pushing me down and trying to take things further. He's being really cool about it."

"He asked you if you're okay with it."

"Right, he did. But he didn't make it like a big deal and he wasn't like a nervous little boy or anything."

You mean like I'd be? "So you like that?"

"I did. Like he's a really good-looking guy, Harrison. Really good-looking."

"That's good."

"And like everybody knows him, they all think he's cool, they all want to talk to him. And he's with me in this house..."

"Do you have any idea how hot you are?"

"I know. You should see it here, Harrison. There're tons of good-looking girls here."

"So what are you saying?"

"I'm saying, like this guy's attitude is really great. I'm making out with him and he's not acting like some randy sex maniac. You know, out of control and making me do things that he wants rather than what I want. He's just chill and letting it all happen."

"You're saying chill a lot."

"They say that. And this guy's chill, Harrison."

"Yeah, okay."

"So I'm looking at this guy who could have sex with any girl, like they're falling all over him at this party out in the woods, but that he's there with me. We're talking and we're like making a connection, we're making out, and he's just—"

"Chill."

She shrugged. "Right. It just made me feel really good about him."

"Sounds like he's a really great guy," he said, meaning it sarcastically but purposely removing the venom from his voice.

"I'm telling you you would like him, Harrison."

"Fine. I'm sure I would like him."

"Are you ready for more?"

He exhaled heavily. "Sure. Hit me."

Her mouth grew tight and her lips squirmed. She said, "I took it out."

He jolted, grabbed his hip and squeezed it between two fingers and thumb.

She said, "I can stop."

"Keep going," he said.

"I took his dick out."

"Why?"

She gave him an exasperated look, frowned at him as if saying What do you think?

"Did you have sex with him?" he said, and hearing his own words chilled him.

She said, "It was weird, like I said I was having all these good feelings for him, but I didn't really feel like I wanted him touching me. But I wanted him to feel... I guess, pleasure...?"

"So what did you do?"

“I asked him if he wanted a hand job.”

“I’m sure great-guy-Tripp was all over it.”

“Don’t be a jerk, Harrison.”

He shrugged, stared at her and she stared back. He said, “Will you just let me be a jerk, please? I want to hear this, but I can’t help my reactions.”

“Yeah, but your reactions make me feel like an idiot. Make me feel like I’m a bad person.”

“You’re not a bad person,” he moaned.

Her expression grew serious, worried even. She said, “Harrison, it’s really bad what we did.”

“But I want this,” he said. “We said we would.”

“I know, but I don’t think you’re ready.”

“Wait—what do you mean *it’s* bad? What we did, you and me? Or what you and Tripp did?”

“What me and Tripp did.”

He moaned again, squeezed at his hip. He breathed with his mouth open for a minute, looking away from the iPad. He said, “Tell me.”

“If you hate me, Harrison, I’m going to be so fucking mad at you.”

“I’m not going to hate you. Tell me what happened.”

“I told you, I took his dick out...”

“Yeah, and you offered him a hand job.”

“And he was cool with that...”

He bit his tongue. Nodded. *Yes, I’m sure he was. Sure he was delighted.*

“...So, I started to, you know, jerk him off.”

His own cock was throbbing, aching like it was a rotten tooth. He squeezed it through his pants, could feel how iron it was right now.

“Okay?” She looked at him for a long while, and he wondered if she knew that he was hard right now and was squeezing himself. He stopped what he was doing, stared back at her. She said, “I think... your dick is bigger than his.”

It totally shocked him. His head darted back, and his eyes fluttered. Now he could feel red pounding in his cheeks. Could feel his heartbeat in his ears, could feel his ears burn red.

She laughed, said, “Look at your face. Oh, my God, you like that?”

“Shut up,” he said.

She giggled and laughed, her iPad camera flicking around as she rolled in her bed for a moment. When it went still again, she was on her side. It

was like she was looking down on him. She said, "Look at your face. You like hearing that?"

"Of course I do," he said. "Of course I do."

"Oh, wow, look how happy your face is, Harrison. I should have told you that first."

She'd got him laughing. He wiped at his eyes with the back of his wrist.

"Yeah, I think your dick's a little bit bigger than his."

"A little bit?"

She shrugged. "I think it's a little longer."

That unexpected happiness wavered a bit as he let that soak in. "So his is thicker?"

"Yeah, his is thicker. He's pretty thick."

Now that happiness curled up in a ball and died. "Oh," he said.

"But I think yours is longer."

"You think?"

"I think so," she said.

"And," she said, suddenly remembering something and getting eager. "He had a foreskin."

"That's really great," he said.

"Harrison, stop." She said it firm, adamant.

"Go on," he said, "sorry. So he had a foreskin..."

"It was really... *neat*."

He made a scoffing sound showing her he was grossed out. "It *was*? Neat, Taylor? That's gross." When he looked to the screen again, he saw her sullen, looking down like a scolded girl. He felt guilty, said, "For a guy to hear."

She said, "See, this is where I don't know what to say, Harrison. I want to be honest, then you say things that make me feel stupid. I *want* to be honest, I *do*, I feel like we're sharing something here. I'm sharing with *you*. I know you're my boyfriend, but you're also my *friend* friend. I want to be able to tell you things, but what I just said now then you said it's gross, I feel so ashamed."

"Like your *girl* friend? Like Kay?"

"You're the one who wants me to tell you everything."

"You'd tell Kay about Tripp's amazing foreskin?"

"Stop, Harrison, I didn't say it was amazing. I would tell Kay about it."

“She’d probably say the guy was an uncircumcised loser.” He was looking away, and while he meant that—it *was* what Kay would probably say—he could hear the humor in it. When he looked to Taylor she was smiling. He smirked.

“I’d just never seen one before.”

“A foreskin?”

She nodded.

“Sorry,” he said, “it’s not gross.”

“Is it? You’re a guy; *my* guy. Do you *want* to hear this?”

“Yes, I really do. I swear I won’t say anything snarky again. I mean it.”

“But is it gross for me to say that?”

“No.”

“Is it gross that I... you know, *liked* it?...” She hunched her shoulders, wincing like she was expecting a loud noise coming.

“Liked his foreskin? You mean you like uncircumcised penises?”

“No, I don’t. I don’t think I do. I just mean *his* penis. Tripp’s. Am I gross that it turned me on?”

“Did it?”

She nodded, looking worried. “It did.”

“I’m a jerk,” he admitted. “I want to know, then I say shitty things when you open up...” He rubbed his forehead.

“Maybe we should stop.”

“No, no, no,” he said hurriedly.

“Are you sure?”

“I feel close to you. And...” He paused to consider admitting something to her.

“What?...”

“And... like, maybe it’s having an effect on me.”

“What is?”

“Hearing your story.”

“What kind of effect?” she asked, looking serious like she couldn’t make the connection in her mind though he thought it was obvious.

“Like, I might like it... *down there*...” He let his eyes go to the bottom of the iPad’s screen and nodded his chin between his legs and she got it.

“Are you serious?”

“Yes,” he said, letting the S sound drag in an embarrassed hiss.

“So you really do mean this.”

“Yes, I want to hear. Tell me all your secrets, Taylor, I want to hear them.”

She chuckled, looked away, smiling, touching the point of her glistening little tongue to the corner of her mouth. “I liked how Tripp’s dick felt in my hand, so I wanted to see it.”

That coy look on her face, the resumption of her terrible confession, knowing she liked how another guy’s dick felt in her gentle grip, turned him on so bad. His cock suddenly surged harder, and he flexed it, held it long and hard. He exhaled, said, “See his foreskin?”

“Yeah, I wanted to see what it looked like.”

Now he was squeezing his thighs together, digging his heels into the mattress.

She said, “I told him to turn the flashlight on, but keep it low.”

“So he did that?” He slipped a hand down and gave his cock a squeeze. It throbbed in his grip.

“Yeah, he just turned it on and aimed it toward the back of the couch, and it lit us up but you probably couldn’t see it from outside.”

“That would be terrible.” His voice had faded to quiet.

She eyed him, trying to judge whether that was sarcastic or not. She said, “Anyway, I played around with it, you know—”

“Checking out his foreskin.”

“Right.”

“What did you like about it?”

She sniffed, wiggled her nose, drew in a long breath; her eyes studied him the whole while. “You could see the... *head*... under the skin. The shape of it. The skin wriggled around, and like, I could stroke him but the foreskin stayed covering, mostly. But if I looked at the tip, there was this bird’s nest of folded skin, and inside I could see how shiny the head was, could see the hole in it.”

“Cheezus, fuck,” he groaned, kicking his legs up and down in the bed, writhing like he was in agony.

“Is that too much?”

He looked to see her face closer to the camera, grimacing, watching him. He hid his face away, said, “Is it gross that’s exactly what I want to know? Much as I hate it...”

“You do?”

He nodded.

“Harrison, look at me.”

He rolled his head around, embarrassed he’d admitted that, met her eyes on the screen.

She said, “I like that you want to know that.”

Softly, he said, “I don’t feel so far from you when you can tell me something so secret. Like distance isn’t anything when you let me inside your head like that.”

She smiled warmly. “You’re the sweetest guy, Harrison.”

“Tell me everything, Taylor. You can’t hurt me...”

Chapter Ten

TAYLOR

LAST NIGHT

SHE SQUEEZED Tripp's erection in her grip, watched how all that extra skin just kind of wriggled on the top like a fleshy crown. She could see the shape of his cock head under that thick skin, the swollen lip of its flared helmet edge rippling underneath. She leaned forward and look straight down, saw the smooth polished skin underneath, looking like it was oiled, the pee hole yawning and closing with her strokes. She told him, "Your dick is so sexy."

Tripp chuckled, pushed back into the seat and made a low sound. "Oh, shit," he groaned.

"You like that?"

"I sure do," he said.

"Good," she said, squirming a little closer to him, pushing her shoulder into his. She was on her knees and he sat with his shorts unzipped, legs wide open and feet on the floor. She whispered in his ear, "Your penis is kind of cold," then giggled.

He said, "You're rubbing some warmth into it."

"You don't want it to get frostbite and fall off."

"No," he groaned, eyes closing a little as she plucked his cock head with her fingers. She smiled, liking her affect on him, then ran the pads of her fingers down the belly of his erection into the folds of his shorts. She said, "How are your balls?"

"Probably pretty shriveled," he said.

She moved her hands around in the crotch of his shorts, felt nothing but the wide underside of his cock. She said, "They're not even here."

"I have them. I have two of them."

"I'll take your word for it."

That got them both giggling, their chests shaking but keeping most of their laughs in their throats. She kissed his neck, leaned on him again.

Now she watched that thing in her hand, the light from the flashlight pointing seat-ward on the other side of his thigh, making things dim but high contrast. She could see his penis and liked it. She played with it a little, both of them looking down at her hand working on it. She rolled the foreskin up and down, then got a little braver with it, taking it pinched between thumb and finger and pulling it to see how it would stretch. She let it go, let it recoil, pulled at it again. She said, "Such a sexy dick," and it got him laughing again.

She kissed his ear now, threw a leg over his so she straddled his lap. Still in her sweatshirt, still in her shorts, she was looking down on his handsome face. She cupped his cheeks, kissed his mouth. She leaned forward, the hardness of his erection pressing against the inside of her thigh, thought maybe it was even sliding up inside her short leg. She let it, flexed her thigh to get it to press against her. That got Tripp's kiss groaning in her mouth.

His hands came up and held her face too. He said, "You're fucking unbelievable, Taylor. You are wild."

She sat back down, her ass just above his knees. Her hand searched around between her legs until she found his bare cock, and she played with it again, looking in his eyes. She said, "We don't want this to be cold, do we?"

He shook his head no, eager to see what this sexy girl from faraway Michigan was capable of. Now she got on the other side of him, grabbed the flashlight, tossed it to where she'd been sitting before. She kissed his chin, kissed his throat, and he tilted his head back. She had his cock in one hand and was stroking it, then eased back, crouching low like a cat ready to pounce, her mouth inches away from the head of his cock.

She heard him moan, "Oh, fuck..."

She lowered her mouth over him. He was thick, and the head of his penis was *really* large. He wasn't crazy huge or anything, maybe not even as long as Harrison's, but she liked the feel of that large, plump shape

slipping into her mouth. When she pressed the ring of her lips, the foreskin yielded, and she could feel the cock head sliding out of its sleeve. She gripped his cock near the base and yanked the skin down to expose that sensitive shape of him.

The tip of her tongue pushed into his pee hole, licked all around the edges of his cock head; she bobbed her head a little up and down on it. Then she was nipping at his foreskin with her pinched lips, pulling it back up with her mouth to cover the glans, then forming a tight ring and sliding it back, each time making Tripp groan and his thighs tremble. Sometimes she would test the elasticity of his foreskin, slip her tongue underneath and wipe it around.

She did that for a long while, taking her time with it. Tripp let her, didn't hasten her blow job, just sometimes caressed the back of her head, but mostly rested his hand on the upper corner of her back. She knew he figured that that was available real estate but if there weren't any No Trespassing signs that hand would be going lower, slipping down her tailbone, maybe inside her shorts. And giving him this pleasure was bringing an excitement out in her, too. She could feel it in her heartbeat, and as she shifted, bobbing her head in his lap, she could feel a slipperiness between her own legs.

Eventually she got him very close to coming. She stopped quickly, got up on her knees so she could see his face. She said, "Tell me when you're going to come."

He nodded. "I won't come in your mouth."

She said, "It's not that, I want to see it."

"What do you mean?"

"I want to see it come out."

He raised his eyebrows, but his lids went sleepy. He sighed, "Oh, my God..."

"What?" She laughed.

"You're amazing," he said.

"I'm not like this," she said, meaning into dirty sex, and feeling her happy expression fade.

He shook his head, said, "I didn't mean anything, I just mean I'm loving this..."

She brightened again, said, "That's what I want to hear."

He nodded, and while she was going to dip down, put her mouth back on him again, use her hand until she could watch the ropes wiggle out of him, she was frozen with sudden surprising lust. She thought of Colt, and how she'd made him come, thought how it leapt out of his extra-large baby maker and went in her hair. How she hated that, hated having it in her hair, and yet loved it, too.

Tripp could tell she was frozen, their eyes locked together, his beginning to narrow with concern. He said, "What? Are you okay?"

She had teeth clamped over her lower lip, and she smiled wide enough it pulled free. She nodded, her hands on his chest and squeezing his body underneath the cotton T-shirt. She tucked her hands in the front, pulled it up, and Tripp hunched forward so they could remove it together. When he sat back, she saw his body. He was tanned, no tattoos of crosses or snakes, just lean, sinewy muscle, a dozen folded lines at his midsection, a fuzzy trail coming up from his dick and fizzling out around where his navel would be. She said, "I love your body."

"You're driving me crazy," he said.

"Why?"

"I don't like being passive."

She nodded now, caressed her hands over his chest, went over his shoulders, squeezed them to feel if they were hard and strong, and they were. Her hands went down his arms, down to his wrists, her right hand circling there, then two hands coming together to pull his hand and push it underneath her T-shirt. His big hand spread across her ribs, the fingertips touching the bottom of her bra. He caressed her breasts over top of the spandex fabric, she unbuttoned her shorts, did down the zipper. She straddled him again, getting right over his face now, took his wrist in both hands again, getting it out from under her shirt and turning it so she could push it into the front of her shorts.

Now Tripp's face collapsed into bottomless lust. His eyes went hazy, glossy, and lost. His two middle fingers slipped into her underwear, right between the folds of her petals, curved and slipped inside her. She collapsed against him, her face buried in his neck.

"Oh, God," she panted, "oh, wow..."

"You're sure?" he asked.

"Oh, yeah," she said and used her girl muscles to squeeze on his two fingers. He slipped them in and out, and her hand was between them,

frantically looking for that thick dick of his. She got it, and with three fingers across the top side, her thumb under the chin, used his foreskin to jerk him quickly.

“Oh, shit,” he said, and started panting. “Oh, no, don’t, don’t, don’t, I’m too close...”

“Okay, hold on,” she said, “hold on,” and put both hands on his shoulders, her face still hidden in his neck. She breathed in that woodsy scent, felt his fingers plunging in and out of her. “Shit,” she hissed, got up on her knees, let him finger her while she pulled her sweatshirt and shirt off. She leaned forward, said in his ear, “Bra,” and Tripp’s other hand was quick to unclasp it. They both pulled it free, and she shoved a nipple into his mouth.

“Oh, fuck,” she shouted, feeling the warm wet of his mouth on her. His fingers were plunging deeper now, and his sucking moved from nipple to nipple. Taking a breast in each hand, she fed them to him and began to grind in his lap.

It became overwhelming. “Oh, wait, wait, wait, wait,” she said.

He stopped quickly. His fingers were still inside her. He said, “You want me to stop?”

She bit her lower lip, guided his hand out from her shorts, saw the shine she left on his fingers. She stepped back, stood in front of him between his open legs.

He asked, “Are you okay?”

She stood there watching him breathing heavy, looking at his sexy body, his long legs, his thick penis sticking straight up, the foreskin half over his fat cock head. She said, “You look so fucking good.”

He said, “You’re the hottest thing I’ve seen...”

Even though she didn’t want to do this tonight, now she did. She thumbed down her pants and underwear, stepped her legs out of them, and Tripp groaned with appreciation.

“God,” he said, “look at your body, look at your legs...”

Totally naked now, she bent over his lap and pulled his shorts down. He shot his hips forward so she could get them off, and she liked the way his dick bounced against his stomach as she pulled his pants off.

Now they were both naked, and she didn’t know what she was doing.

He said, “You sure?”

She shook her head no.

He said, "We could stop."

She shook her head no, straddled his lap again. Now his hard cock was pressing the inside of her thigh, and if she bent her knees a little she could feel it pressing up in the apex of her crotch, at the outside of her opening, the outside of her vulva. She whispered in his ear, "Just a little bit, okay?"

"Just a little bit what? Inside you?"

"Yeah," she gasped.

"You sure?"

"I'm sure," she said.

"I have a condom in my shorts..."

"Just please, please, *now*," she said.

Tripp's hand shoved between them, gripped the base of his cock. She raised up a little, and he swiped it in her folds. She could feel the large, round shape of his glans slipping in between her membranes. "Yes," she said, "that's it, just a little..."

"Ease back," he told her and put a hand on her shoulder. He held his dick upright, and she sat back down on it, feeling the head push her opening apart and slip inside her. "I want to feel what it's like..."

"What what's like?"

"Your cock," she said.

His expression narrowed. "Are you a virgin?"

"No," she laughed, then got close and whispered, "Foreskin."

"Oh," he said, and she felt bad because she hadn't wanted to mention it at all in case he was sensitive about it. So she said, "It's so sexy," and scratched her nails on his chest.

He groaned, said, "I should get my condom."

"It's okay," she said, "we're not going to do anything."

"I don't want to get carried away..."

"I'm on the pill," she said.

"Are you sure?"

"Am I sure I'm on the pill," she said and laughed, the flexing of her tummy making his cock slip inside her a little, bringing bright white sheets of pleasure behind her eyes.

"Are you sure?"

"I'm sure I'm on the pill, Tripp. Do you *need* a condom?"

He didn't say anything but she could feel him shake his head no.

"I'm trusting you."

“You can,” he whispered.

The pleasure was insane. The feeling of just a few inches of him inside her had her brain doing cartwheels and somersaults. It was hard to concentrate, hard to focus; everything she had was down to a pinpoint hard-column pushing inside the most sweetly sensitive part of her. “Just a little more,” she said, and sank back down on him.

“If you don’t want to do this...”

“I don’t,” she said. “Just this, okay?”

“I might come...”

“Okay,” she said. “I want to see it.”

“I remember...”

“Oh, God,” she gasped, her hands turning to fists on his chest and lightly beating against him. “You feel so fucking good,” she told him.

“Taylor, you’re killing me. You feel unbelievable...”

“Just a little more,” she said, taking maybe another half-inch inside her.

“Okay,” she said, “that’s it,” and raised until his erection fell out of her and she heard the wet slap of his heavy penis against his stomach. She grabbed it quickly and started jerking it. It got him squirming underneath her and she said, “God, I’m so wet I left your dick soaking...”

Tripp groaned, chuckled, his hands came up her sides to pull her forward so he could take a nipple in his mouth again. Her eyes rolled up in her head, and she let his dick go, raising up high so he could suck on her. He took both nipples, one at a time, over and over, until he had her gasping.

She reached behind her, found his hardness and gripped it underhanded. She sat back, guided it inside her again. His thick size pushed her out wonderfully. He filled her up, and she took him only a few inches deep again. Hands on his chest, she squiggled her hips, like her pussy was giving him a hand job.

Tripp was breathing heavy and despite the cold, she could see they’d both broken a sweat. His muscle gleamed in the low beam of the flashlight. His muscles stood out, and the veins rose up across his shoulders and down his arms. “So fucking sexy,” she said and caressed him, her hand squeezing at his shoulders, running down his biceps and his hard forearms.

The full and large size of his skin-protected cock head was driving her crazy. That was his man-part. His sex spot. The head of his cock was the point of pleasure, a swollen, bursting pleasure-cherry, and when it got rubbed, it sent the signal to open the gates and deliver the seed. And Tripp’s

was protected. Natural. Biological. Thick skin that kept that round helmet from rubbing in his jeans or his undies, kept it vital and alive and eager for touch. It kept his pleasure-point sensitive; his seed propulsion teetering with a hair-trigger. And, God, the shape and size of it... large and round, the surrounding lip pronounced, giving his fat cock a plunger-seal—when he pumped his seed inside her none of it would leak, none of it would squirt down the sides. When he came—when a man came he pumped harder and deeper, wanting to drive all his liquid DNA into your belly, make you fat and pregnant with his baby...

She sunk a little lower, said, “Shit, fuck it, fuck it,” and squashed down, taking him all the way inside her. Tripp tightened and let out a low masculine howl. He squeezed her waist, gripped her, his whole body going tight. He’d gone rigid because his male animal was telling him to hold this girl tight and fuck her hard. He kept her pinched down in his lap so he wouldn’t thrust, but she could feel his cock flexing and surging inside her, desperate to be plunging in and out.

She was desperate to get fucked now. She said, “Fuck me, just fuck me...”

“Yes,” he shouted, gripped her hipbones, pushed himself deep, raising her up off the couch then dropping down, then using his hands on her, he bounced and found a thrust-rhythm, her going up and down his shaft, both of them bouncing on the couch and making its bark legs squeak on the dirty old golf club floor. They both shouted and gasped; she shrieked, bit her arm, bit his shoulder.

“Oh fuck,” he said, wrapping his arms around her upper back, hand gripping her neck, fucking her harder and harder; his balls had made an appearance now (lots of warmth in the room, thank you very much), she could feel them bouncing and shaking under her ass.

“Fuck,” she said, “your dick is so good, God, fuck me...”

“You’re so tight,” he said, “so fucking tight...”

She said, “You’re so fucking thick, feels like your fist is going in me...”

“Ah, mm, shit,” he said, pinched his fingers into her, dug himself deep.

She said, “Come inside me...”

He said, “You wanted to see it...”

“Come inside me,” she told him again.

And Tripp needed no further instruction, grabbing the tops of her thighs, pushing her down into his lap, bucking on the couch and getting the back

banging against the wall, making the old brittle window glass rattle in its frame. Both of them were calling out passionate, loud, and high and vigorous. Shouts and cries, as they both came to orgasm. She hit it first, and it was the feel of the shape of his dick inside her. So thick, the head so plump, and the way she sat on him pushed it against her front wall. She cried out as she collapsed, bit at his neck, and he fucked her even harder.

“Come,” she shouted, “come!” Tripp growled and roared, and she said again, “Come inside me...”

Then he bucked her high so her knees came right off the couch and she was fully on top of him, his heels pushed on the floor, his shoulders on the couch back, his butt high in the air, her on top of him like she rode a horse. His cock swelled larger inside her and she could feel the underside of it bulging and releasing as he pumped her full of his seed.

“Oh, God,” she cried, and that fading orgasm she had did a loop-the-loop, came up behind itself and whispered in her ear again. Now she was orgasming with him, her eyes fluttering, her stomach going tight and hard, pushing against her skin like a steel pipe. “Oh God,” she shouted, “I feel it, I feel you coming...”

Chapter Eleven

HARRISON

HAND INSIDE HIS PAJAMA PANTS, he jerked his cock and listened to Taylor tell him the most disgusting and horrifying things he'd ever heard. He was wincing, moving his hand, trying not to get his shoulder going up and down so she would see it. Every movement of his hand sent heaven-bolts into his brain. The bulging knob of his cock head was electric. His breath came in short hitches, ecstasy swirled in his heart, yet tears had squeezed in his eyes.

"He... He came inside you?..." His voice was stretched tight-wire thin, a creaky high vibrato. His stomach heaved in and out, and his balls felt like swollen grapefruits. He was caught in erotic hell. Trapped and being punished for some sin he didn't even know he'd committed. It was torture to find pleasure in so much pain, a creeping, crawling feeling that had him hating every word that came out of her mouth while his finger curled at her to bring more of them. *Tell me how it felt... Tell me how you loved it... Tell me everything...*

"He came... He came inside me," she panted. The latter part of her story had both of them seemingly on the verge of tears. Taylor's voice thick with sobs, and his breath coming heavy through sadness and a swollen nose. He could see her eyes were red, could see a droplet of a tear in the corner, trapped in her lashes.

"He came inside you?..." He squeezed his cock, brought more insane pleasure bursting in his heart. *Why did it have to be like this?*

"He did," she panted, "he came... *inside* me..." twisting her head on the pillow. Her teeth were clenched. The tendon rose in her neck.

He knew that face. His expression dropped, he watched it with growing alarm. "Taylor...?"

She shook her head no, eyes closed off, that sparkling tear turned into a rivulet that disappeared into her hairline above her sweet little ear.

"Taylor...?" A thick, wet sobbing sound came from her. "What are you doing?"

"Tell me what you want to hear," she murmured.

"Are you touching yourself?" She shook her head but gave no other answer. "Are you?"

Her shoulders came up, and she shook her head no again, and then he could see Harry Bear propping up into the bottom of the frame as she hugged the stuffed guy to her chest.

"It's okay," he gasped, surprised he meant it. "It's okay..."

Her mouth wriggled and her cheeks went bright red like she would cry. She still shook her head no.

He said, "I am," saying it bold. She shook her head no again, and he said, "I'm touching myself..."

She turned her chin up, eyes wide and staring upward at whatever was at the top of her bed, blinking and breathing heavy.

"Do it," he urged her, "do it, Taylor."

She shook her head, and he told her, "We both will, come on just like last time..."

Now her chin came down, and she watched him from California, the two of them with faces glued to their iPads. He could tell when she touched herself again because her eyes fluttered. "Do it, do it," he whispered, and resumed stroking himself. "He came inside you...?"

"He came inside me, Harrison, because... I *asked* him to."

"It's hot," he told her, the truth starting to squeeze out of him. All those barriers he'd thrown in her face, his disgruntled replies, were just defensive shields keeping her out from his true self. He wanted this for her, he wanted the hurt though he knew he didn't deserve it...

"He came inside me, Harrison..."

"But you wanted to see it..." He stroked a little faster,

She made a mumbling groan, and he could tell she was wriggling around in her bed, holding the iPad awkwardly, her other hand probably feathering over her clit or putting fingers inside herself.

He said, "You did, didn't you?"

“I wanted to see it... and I did.”

“He came inside you...”

“When he pulled out...” She gasped and stiffened, some erotic spike taking her suddenly higher, making her body stiffen.

“When he pulled out... What?...”

“When he pulled out, I could feel it dribbling, and I got up over him, hugged his head, pushed with my tummy and made it all come out of me...”

“Oh, fuck,” he groaned, his stroke turning liquid on himself. His cock flexed and bucked in his grip. “You’re so fucking bad...”

“Not bad...” she said, brow furrowing, eyes closed.

“Great,” he said, “great,” his chest heaving as he stroked.

“I pushed it all out, I made it come out and drip on his stomach...”

“Oh, God,” he said, his iPad jostling all over the place as he was almost consumed by an impending orgasm.

“Pushed it all out of me, and then I... smeared it on him...”

“With what?...”

“My... mm, pussy,” she whispered.

Harrison groaned a tight sound, his back arched, and his cock jumped in his hand. A stream of semen spurted up to his chin, more bursts went all up his chest, all over his stomach; he squeezed and caressed himself, and he heard Taylor making a cooing sound.

Her eyes were open, and she was watching him. “You’re coming?” she asked him.

“Oh, God,” he grunted, squirming, feeling semen still pulsing from him.

“Are you coming?”

“Fuck yes,” he growled.

Taylor closed her eyes, gasped, and he watched her face, and just like he’d done a few nights ago, he got to watch what she looked like when she came—up close and personal. Point blank. Her lips peeled back from her perfect white teeth clenched together in an even line, her swan-like neck arched gracefully across her pillow, a vein pulsing below her ear. Then she began to work her mouth open and closed and made the softest most exciting feminine coughing sounds as she came. Pleasure still swirled in his belly but now a wonderful leather-clad glove thumped him in his breastbone, aiming right for his chest. *Is she thinking of you? Or is she thinking of some guy from California who knocked her socks off last night, some fucking tanned nice-guy asshole called Tripp?*

He grabbed his cock and stroked it again, more electric pleasure sizzling across his brainpan. "Oh, fuck, Taylor," he moaned, stroking hard and watching her still ride out an orgasm.

Was she thinking of Colt? Was she thinking of someone else?...

He twisted in the sheets, and a thin, waterless orgasm twisted him again. Nothing erupted from him, but the flip-over switch of an orgasm being thrown, making his brain go lights-out for a moment. Her awful story got both of them panting, both of them looking at each other bewildered now, chests heaving in and out, both of them with flushed cheeks and shining eyes. Taylor couldn't even talk, squeaking for breath.

He saw the trouble in her eyes, said, "It's okay, it's okay..."

"I'm sorry," she gasped.

"It's okay," he told her.

"We..." She panted a moment, continued, "We cleaned up, we went... We left..."

"Back down... Back down to the road...?"

She shook her head no, a tear rolled down her cheek, and she wiped it away with her fingers. She sniffed wetly, said, "The other way, we cut across and it comes out on campus..." She shook her head like she wanted to say more but needed to swallow first. But when she swallowed she said nothing, snorted again, new tears on her cheeks.

"It's okay," he said.

"I love you," she sobbed.

"I love you too, you are so precious..."

That made her sob again, and she sniffed, said, "I have to blow my nose..."

"Go blow your nose," he said.

"I gotta go," she said, "I gotta go, okay?..."

"Don't go," he said.

"I have to, Harrison, sorry, I love you, okay? We'll talk later..."

"I love you, Taylor, I love you so much..."

She nodded, said, "Talk to you later, okay?" Her face had pinched tight and gone redder, looking like she would cry.

He nodded, and the screen went black as Taylor closed off the connection.

He lay in bed, chest streamed with his wet, his iPad fallen to the bed at his side. His pajama pants were pushed down to the top of his thighs, his

erection fading in his lap. He looked up at the ceiling, panted.

Up above him he could hear SportsLine, his dad home from work and in his den catching up on the games he missed. Life going on around him. His mom and dad like nothing was happening, life as usual. Kelsey Kay learning how to be a good student. Taylor moving on, making friends, getting laid like a normal person in their first year at college. He was trapped in her clutch. Trapped in her graceful-fingered grip as she squeezed him tight. But he didn't want it any other way. Or did he? Could this be any good? His insides were twisting into a wet knot that maybe could never be untied. Everything that made him a happy person becoming confused, being soaked in liquid badness. Like Sunday school lessons on sin, he was letting the bad human inside him win. He should tell Taylor to break it off, tell her his heart couldn't take it. But what kind of man would he be if his heart couldn't take it? If you loved Taylor, this was what you loved. If you gave up on her, you never deserved her in the first place.

A commercial blared now, his dad's den directly above, and he put his hands over his ears, shutting off the sound but it didn't squeeze out any of the sickness in him. He pictured Taylor sitting on some tall guy's lap, his thick cock inside her, her bouncing on him, loving it. Not wanting to love it, but giving in to her secret-most desires. Wanting it, but trying to be good. Being good for him. Until she couldn't. Giving in. Giving in to being a young girl curious about sex with other boys. Was he weighing her down?

"Fuck, fuck, fuck," he chanted, brought his fists down to thump on the bed. He pulled his pajama pants up, rolled over onto his side. Semen tickled in his meager chest hair. He grabbed at his T-shirt to mop it up. Now from above, the tune of an annoying jingle featuring a 1-800 number, and he said to the room, "Shut the fuck up."

He climbed off the bed, getting on the floor on his hands and knees, arching his back, sucking in his stomach then pushing it out. Nothing would ease the tightness in his heart. He got down and lay flat on his floor and started to quietly cry, his breath coming long and shaky, his sobs almost silent. Then he wormed himself on his elbows, got under the bed like he used to when he was eight and he wanted to escape. Back in his hidey-hole, under the bed, peeking out from where it was safe. He curled up under there, brought his forearms over his chest in an X and tightened his stomach and clenched his fists. "You're not going to break me, Taylor," he murmured, "you're not going to break me, you're not going to break me..."

Chapter Twelve

TAYLOR

LAST NIGHT

SEMEN SPUTTERED FROM HER PUSSY, making slick crackling sounds as she flexed her stomach. She watched it drip from her and bead up in the hair around Tripp's navel. Then she squatted down on him, mushed her vagina against his stomach and smeared it on him. When she looked up, Tripp was wide-eyed. His mouth hung open in an expression of bewilderment. It dawned on her how crazy she was being, and her own mouth fell. But just when she thought she would be overcome by embarrassment, Tripp smiled, hands moving from her waist to curve both sides of her neck.

"So unbelievable," he said, the softness of his voice conveying sincerity.

She laughed, fell forward, kissed him. He took the angles of her jaw in his big hands and guided her mouth to his. They kissed, slowly, luxuriously. His cock was between them, wide but deflating, hardness leaving it. She could feel it against the inside of her thigh.

Now she leaned to the side, trying to get out of his lap, and Tripp supported her with his hands, guiding her so they both lay facing each other on the couch, her back toward the open lobby. She moaned, put her hands over her face.

"What?" he asked with a laugh and guided one of her hands away.

She peeped at him, looking at that handsome and compassionate face as he studied her. She said, "I didn't think we were going to be doing that tonight."

The smile didn't leave his face, and he nodded, saying, "I didn't think we were going to be doing that at all, either."

"What did you think?"

"I was hoping that you'd let me kiss you."

"Really," she laughed. "That's all?"

"You put up a lot of barriers."

"I do," she said. "You wanted to get past them?"

He shook his head no, saying, "I just like you, Taylor."

"I like you, too," she said, and uncovered her face, slipped both palms together in the attitude of prayer and rested her cheek on them.

They watched each other for a long while, both of them with easy smiles. She said, "It was pretty good," then laughed.

He chuckled too, said, "It was better than good."

"You think so?" she asked, her smile growing.

"I definitely think so, Taylor," he said. He used two middle fingers to push hair away from her face, her hair gone tangled and heavy from the river water. That tender action of his didn't make her recoil, but it made her smile fade. He noticed. He asked her what's wrong.

She shrugged. "It still feels like cheating."

"You mean on your boyfriend?"

She nodded.

"You guys are open."

"We are," she said. "I'm just trying to be honest. That's how it feels."

"No," he said. "I respect that. It feels like cheating, I'm not gonna say it doesn't. It must be weird for you."

She rolled her shoulder away so she could rest the back of her head against his arm. She stared up at the high wood ceiling.

He asked her, "You dated this guy a long time?"

"Almost three years," she said.

"Holy shit."

"Right?"

"It's so awesome you guys can be cool about going away to separate schools."

"He's been my best friend since I was ten years old."

"That's a long time."

"It got kinda weird this summer, though."

He brushed his thumb on her cheek, studying her profile. He said, "He's good to you?"

"Harrison?" she said, almost laughing. She turned so they faced. "He's the sweetest guy ever. Like, you would really like him. If you met Harrison, you two guys would be best friends, and I'm not even kidding."

He shrugged, now his smile faded a little. She cupped his cheek, offering him the support he'd offered her.

He said, "Is it you?"

"Is it me what?"

"This guy's known you a long time, and he's willing to be open. Was it you that wanted it?"

Now whatever trace of smile she had was completely gone. She said, "I don't want to talk about that."

"Sorry, I don't mean to pry into your biz..."

"Oh, no," she said, "I'm not mad. It's just... I came all this way..."

"You're running away from home?"

She raised her eyebrows. "Yeah, maybe..."

"Running away from your boyfriend?"

She pursed her lips, lowered her brow and couldn't look at him. She tried to think of an answer but pushed it away instead because she didn't want to face it. She forced a smile, said, "You would really like him."

"I probably would," he said, "if he's good to you."

"He's the sweetest guy I know."

"You're lucky to have people that care about you," he said, and his hand cupped her neck.

Now she could face him again, they were close and looking in each other's eyes. She said, "You seem like a good guy, too."

"I am."

She cuddled up against him, their faces close, their lips almost touching. She closed her eyes like she might want to sleep and he stroked his hand from her shoulder down to her hip and let it rest there.

Outside, they could hear crickets, could feel the chilled air stirring, coming in the gaps in the old building's structure. The flashlight was behind him, the beam still on and lighting up a half-moon on the leather back of the couch. She studied his body through narrow eyes. His slim waist, the curve of his hip, the darkness between his legs where she couldn't really see. She watched him while he tried to sleep, eyes closed, breathing softly. She

kissed his lips to get him awake. He kissed her in return and caressed her shoulder.

She broke away, said, "It was good, right? You think it can be better?"

"Definitely," he said, sly humor in his eyes, and she was sure he was right. So they made out lying side-by-side on the dirty old couch. Her hand drifted down, found his cock sticky still from her insides, not fully deflated but feeling heavy. She pinched knuckle and thumb over his foreskin and wriggled around the head of his cock while he slipped a hand up her thigh and put a finger inside her. They made out while she gave him a hand job and he fingered her. Taking her time, maybe a quarter of an hour, before she asked him to fuck her again.

She stayed on her back while he got over top. She opened her legs for him, he got between them and she closed her heels around the back of his legs. He looked between them, aimed himself, put that large helmet into her nest of eager sex. He pushed inside her and she gasped. He got close, and she hugged him. They made out, kissing while he put himself inside as far as he could go. He stayed like that, embedded deep, their hips writhing together while their mouths did most of the work. She scratched his back, gave him her tongue. He took it, gave her his. Soon they were both rolling on the couch, gasping and panting and moaning. She grew hotter, grew sweaty. He made her come again. She told him to hold on and he waited. They started again, and he brought her over one more time. When it was his turn, she asked him to show her. He pulled it out of her when he was ready, and she tugged on her sides to make the flat of her stomach even flatter. The semen squirted out of him. She watched that turtleneck wrinkle and roll over and retract from that succulent shape of his cock head. Then a long white rope came out in an S and flopped on her stomach. Her skin was warm so she didn't feel its heat, but she could feel its wet. Her hands went instantly to it, smeared through it. Tripp ejaculated more over her wrists and fingers. She squeezed him with her thighs, felt a roaring rolling lust build up in her belly. She almost came again, maybe she did, *something* seized her... She played with the mess he left on her stomach, and he got onto his elbows and made out with her.

THEY NAPPED FOR OVER AN HOUR. When Tripp woke her again, it was two in the morning. He said, "We should get going."

“Yeah,” she agreed, “we should.” They sat up, both bent over, sitting side-by-side, snatching their clothing from the floor. Tripp threw his sweatshirt over her head, being playful and drying her hair. She giggled under the cotton as he shook his hands over her hair and squeezed it out. When he pulled the sweatshirt away, he traced a finger down her arm and kissed the back of her shoulder. Her nipples grew hard, and she covered them.

Over her shoulder, she said, “It was just sex, okay?”

“Sure thing,” he said, and pulled his T-shirt on. They got dressed in the dark and the quiet, his flashlight turned off now. When they were ready, he switched it back on with his hand cupped over the beam and led them back out the way they came. They slipped past the no trespassing fence, and she asked him how far away they were from campus.

“I think we’re only about twenty minutes from the dorm,” he said, pointing deeper into the woods.

She said, “Not the way we came?”

“No, it’s just straight through that way, I don’t think it’s far at all.”

She looked warily at the dark maw of a trail in the jagged swath of tree-line. “Is it safe?”

“I got you,” he said, and they walked through a clearing with his arm draped over her shoulders, and her with her hands tucked up in the sleeves of her sweatshirt and cuddling herself.

They walked through the woods until they found a beaten trail. They followed that for a while until they found an intersection where he shone the flashlight and lit up a pole with directional arrows posted all up and down it. He said, “See, told you. We go that way,” flashing their light further down the trail in the direction he’d intended.

“You’re so smart,” she said.

“I checked my phone while you’re sleeping.”

“You didn’t use Orion or whatever?”

“I’m not a Boy Scout and I’m not a sailor.”

She laughed, said, “But you’re pretty good at using a smart phone.”

“Lots of practice,” he said, and put his arm around her again.

They walked in silence until they could see the distinct rigidly geometrical light pattern of their university campus. And soon they were in a clearing, seeing the low buildings, open fields.

In the lobby of Fleming, someone was sitting asleep in a lawn chair wearing a bathrobe and sweatpants their hands tucked into opposite armpits, head back on a cushion propped against the wall. They slipped past them, getting into the building climbing the stairs up to their floor. They stopped at his room, and he said, "This is me here."

"I know which room is yours," she said with fake snarkiness.

"So what now? I see you around?"

"If you're lucky," she said, "you might just see me around."

"We're on the same floor..."

"Bound to happen then," she said and shrugged, smiling, then tucking her hands in the back pockets of her shorts.

"Take care, Michigan," he said, not coming in for a kiss.

"You take care, too, Smug Town," she gave him back, sideways smiling, pivoted and did a funny little skipping sashay down the hall with her hands on her ass. She knew he'd be watching, so while she tried to keep it a little funny, she also wanted it to be a little on the sexy side, too. When she went round the corner without even a glance back, she hugged herself with her arms and hunched over. Now back to her room; back in with Makayla...

Chapter Thirteen

TAYLOR

SHE LAID in the dorm room bed so far from home, looking at the ceiling. Her heart was loud in her ears, breaths coming quick. Between her legs a tingling warmth spread, and a lusty knot had tightened in her belly right around where her uterus lay. She orgasmed reliving to Harrison her evening with another boy. And now prickly shame came over her. It wasn't right. It wasn't right to be turned on by that, and it wasn't right to do that to Harrison. And why did *Harrison* want it?

She reached to the table beside her bed, grabbed some tissue, wiped her eyes and blew her nose. Makayla would be back soon and she would have to pretend to be asleep.

After she and Tripp made love on that creepy old couch in that creepy old vampire clubhouse, she'd also felt shame. Shame at not stopping when she hadn't wanted it. It wasn't Tripp's fault in any way. He'd offered a chance to stop anywhere; he'd given her every opportunity. She'd worried from the moment they met in the hall last night it would end in sex. Tripp acted like he didn't see it coming, and *she* sure didn't—not when she'd thought she would resist. But when the fucking was done, it felt *inevitable*.

The tears had diminished and her heartbeat reduced nearer to normal. She moved a hand around, seeking her iPad, found it, brought it to life.

Mouth pursed, pushing to the left and to the right, she stared at the menu screen. Browser brought up, she typed E-D-D-I-E, paused, trying to remember the name her mother had said. Typed an H, saw 'Haskell' appear as a fulfilled search and selected that. What she saw made her exhale a contemptuous raspberry from her pursed lips. *What the hell was Trish*

talking about?... Though she *did* say he was a *hot* Eddie Whoever. And Tripp was definitely hot. She squeezed her nose, looked at this old black and white photo of a nerdy guy from the fifties with blonde hair and not much else like Tripp at all.

Tongue working around the inner curl of her lip, her eyes flicked left and right. Facebook open, she searched 'Tripp Heavens,' found him and friended him. Now a big sigh, her cheeks billowing out. Before she'd exhaled, her request was accepted. Her eyes widened and she chuckled. Now she sent him a message.

Taylor: if you wanted to take me to the boardwalk next weekend I'd probably let you

Afterword

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